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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESENCE IN CC MEET TO BE MADE MANDATORY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

Minister of Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the government is positive to make a legal arrangement for the mandatory attendance of the members in the meeting of the Constitutional Council (CC).

Minister Sharma made this remark while answering the questions raised by the lawmakers during the discussion on the 'Bill to amend the Constitutional Council (Works, Duties, Rights and Procedures) Act, 2066' at the meeting of the State Affairs and Good Governance Committee under the House of Representatives of the Federal Parliament on Sunday.

Minister Sharma, who is also the spokesperson of the government, urged the parliamentarians to focus on the discussion as it is possible to make mandatory arrangements for the members of the council to attend the meeting.

The amendment sought in the bill will also try to seek a solution if the Prime Minister, who used to remain as the chairman of the Council, does not call the meeting of the council intentionally, said Minister Sharma. "The government is ready to proceed accordingly after discussion from this forum and take a concrete decision on the issue as well," said Minister Sharma.

Minister Sharma clarified that the government has also made a provision in the amendment bill to achieve a 60 per cent quorum in the decision-making process of the meeting of the council.

Speaking at the meeting, the MPs suggested the government make necessary legal arrangements to prevent the council meeting from becoming a prisoner of indecision.

Nepali Congress MP and former minister Dilendra Prasad Badu said that the council should have a provision to proceed with its decision-making process by assuming that the members who do not attend the meeting intentionally be considered as present automatically.

He said that due to the intentions of the members of the council in the past, the meeting of the council became a prisoner of indecision, and he said that legal arrangements should be made to prevent that from happening now.

Rashtriya Swatantra Party lawmaker Sovita Gautam insisted that the appointment to the council should not be made based on political divisions. She also noted that the council should be appointed only based on the suggestions given by the experts.

MP Gautam drew the attention of the government to arrange the meeting of the council immediately as there is no legal basis for the calling of the meeting for now.

While participating in the amendment bill, eight lawmakers of different political parties have presented their amendment proposal.

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PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN
Technicians installing road surveillance cameras to monitor speed of vehicles at Maharajgunj Road, Kathmandu.

Police HQ to establish separate financial crime probe bureau

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7



Inspector General of Nepal Police, Basanta Bahadur Kunwar, has said that a separate bureau will be established in Nepal Police to investigate financial crimes and cases related to them.

The Headquarters is mulling over establishing a financial crime bureau as there has been a significant increase in cases of banking offences and financial crimes in the country.

IGP Aryal made this remark while speaking at a province-level crime investigation review conference held in Pokhara of the Gandaki Province on Sunday.

According to a press statement issued by the Police Headquarters on Sunday, IGP Kunwar informed that homework has been carried out for the establishment of a specialised bureau to investigate crimes related to financial crimes.

In Gandaki Province alone, cases relating to financial crimes have increased by 200 per cent in the current fiscal year as compared to last year, IGP Kunwar said.

He said, "Not only on individuals or organisations, financial crimes have a serious impact also on the economy of the entire nation, so the police headquarters has been sensitive to the control of such incidents by establishing a separate bureau soon."

Cyber-crime, drug abuse, social crime and other challenges are emerging in society along with financial crimes, he said.

Inspector General Kunwar said that an action plan for drug control is being prepared and implemented at the district level.

An initiative is being taken to establish a rehabilitation centre under the leadership and management of the police itself. "We are confident that all three levels of government will support the matter," IGP Kunwar said.

He said that due to the increase in international traffic from Nepal for foreign employment, study, and travel, the risk of crime related to financial and drug abuse has increased.

Inspector General Kunwar said that since Pokhara is a major tourist destination in the country, tourism-friendly policing would be expanded in Pokhara.

Police chiefs of all 11 districts of the province participated in the conference organised by the Crime Investigation Branch of the Nepal Police and the Gandaki Province Police Office.

Ruling parties share candidacy, UML fields all 19 candidates

BY RAM PRASAD DAHAL
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The political parties on Sunday remained busy picking their candidates for the National Assembly election as the Election Commission has fixed Monday for filing nominations for the poll.

The EC has scheduled the election for the 19 seats of the NA for January 25.

National Assembly, the Upper House of the Federal Parliament, has 59 members, one-third of them get elected every two years. On March 4 this year, the term of the 20 members is expiring, and 19 of them will be elected on January 25 and one will be nominated by the President.

The ruling six parties succeeded in dividing the seats among them after holding marathon meetings on Saturday and Sunday while the main opposition, the CPN-UML finalised the names of its candidates.

A meeting of the ruling parties- the Nepali Congress, the CPN (Maoist Centre), the CPN (Unified Socialist), Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal, Janamorcha and Janamat Party held on Sunday finalised the seat-sharing.

NA ELECTION

As per the agreement, NC will get 10 seats, the CPN (Maoist Centre) will get six, the CPN (Unified Socialist) two and the Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal one seat. However, the Janamorcha and Janamat Party did not get any seats for the Upper House polls. After sealing the deal, the ruling CPN (Maoist Centre) and Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal finalised the names of their candidates on Sunday.

The NC is nominating one seat each in Koshi Province, Madhes Province, Karnali and Lumbini and two each in Bagmati Province, Gandaki and Sudurpashchim Province.

The CPN-Maoist Centre got one seat each in Koshi, Bagmati, Gandaki, Lumbini, Karnali and Sudurpashchim Province. The Unified Socialist bagged one seat each in Bagmati and Karnali Province. The Janata Samajwadi Party-Nepal got one seat in Madhes.

"The meeting of the ruling parties also agreed to file their candidacies jointly as per agreement. We will discuss the issue in the respective parties separately and finalise the names of candidates," said NC chief whip Ramesh Lekhak after the meeting.

However, the Parliamentary Board of the Nepali Congress decided to pick only one of its 10 candidates because of factional feud by 10 pm Sunday.

NC decided to pick Krishna Sitaula from Koshi Province but was unable to decide other candidates by 10 pm Sunday. After the faction led by Dr. Shekhar Koirala demanded four of the 10 seats to the leaders loyal to him, and party president Sher Bahadur Deuba denied it, Koirala left the meeting venue, resulting in the delay in selecting the candidates.

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EC PUBLISHES FINAL LIST OF VOTERS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The Election Commission of Nepal (ECN) Sunday published the final list of the voters for the National Assembly election scheduled for January 25.

The EC informed that there would be 2047 voters – 549 members from the provincial assemblies and 1498 chiefs and deputies from the local bodies – in the election of the National Assembly of the Federal Parliament.

Province-wide data showed that the largest number of voters is in Madhes Province totalling 374 voters including 107 Provincial Assembly members and 267 local-level chiefs and deputies.

In Koshi, there are 367 voters with 93 PA members and 274 local-level chiefs and deputies who will have the right to vote in the National Assembly election.

Likewise, there are 347 voters in Bagmati province with 110 PA members and 237 local level people's representatives.

In Gandaki, there are 230 voters including 60 PA members and 170 representatives from the local governments while there are 305 voters in Lumbini which is comprised of 87 PA members and 218 chiefs and deputies of the local government.

Similarly, Lumbini has 87 voters from the PA and 218 from the local governments for the NA election while the number in Karnali PA is 40 and 156 from local bodies.

Sudurpashchim province has 53 voters from the PA and 176 chiefs and deputies from the local governments.

According to the ECN, Karnali has the lowest number of voters followed by Sudurpashchim and Gandaki with 196, 228 and 230 voters respectively.

Every voter from the Provincial Assembly will have a vote weightage 53 while local bodies' chiefs and deputies' vote weightage is 19.

The total vote weightage of PA members is 29,097 and local body representatives' weightage is 28,462.

11-point agreement inked on Barathawa incident

BY JANARJAN KHATRI
Sarlahi, Jan. 7

An 11-point agreement has been reached on the Barathawa incident of Sarlahi. The agreement was reached between the protesting group, the family of deceased Jaishankar Sah and the administration.

Chief District Officer of Sarlahi Komal Prasad Dhamala said that the agreement was reached after the discussion held in Barahathawa.

They agreed to investigate the incident, punish the culprits and give appropriate compensation to the deceased's family.

With the agreement, the protesting party withdrew the protest programme and agreed to pick up the body of Sah from the crime scene and take it for the cremation.

It has also been agreed that the Provincial Hospital Barathawa will be named after late Sah.

Similarly, Barathawa Municipality will arrange to employ one member of the dependent family of the deceased Sah.

On the other hand, the meeting also agreed to investigate the guilty police personnel in the shooting and proceed with the process of action against him.

Similarly, the meeting also decided to recommend the process of declaring Sah as a martyr to the relevant body (Ministry of Home Affairs of the centre).

Preparation began to pick the body after the agreement Sunday night.

Sah was shot to death on Friday by the police during a demonstration on the upgradation of the primary health centre at Barathawa-6.

The agreement was reached in the presence of the head of District Security Committee Sarlahi and CDO Dhamala, the victims of the incident, the Finance Minister of Madhes Province, the Minister of Health and Population, the head of Barathawa Municipality, party representatives and concerned persons.

Former PLA members left in state of neglect

BY BOM LAL GIRI
Nawalpur, Jan. 7

Hattikhor in Nawalpur is a camp established by the then CPN-Maoist Army. Later, after the restoration of the peace process, Sewa Dal battalion of the Nepali Army began camping there. The camp has been beautified by planting and colouring trees and constructing pathways, sports arenas and courts.

Meanwhile, outside the camp's gate, there is a settlement in miserable condition. This settlement is home to former Maoist combatants who left the army after the People's Liberation Army (PLA)'s adjustment into the Nepali Army.

Most of the houses here have only two rooms with tin roofs. The area lacks adequate water supplies and is filled with dirt as hens roam freely, the roads are unpaved and materials for thatching like dried Sal leaves are scattered around.

Kumar BK, 45, from the settlement is suffering from an illness that has impaired his ability to speak properly. While visiting him, he was found just staring at the camp he and his fellow



PHOTO: BOM LAL GIRI/TRN
Former People's Liberation Army Kumar BK sitting on the door-step of his house in Hattikhor Camp, Nawalpur.

combatants built. He was wearing worn-out, dirty clothes and his hair was unkempt and matted. It looked like his toenails hadn't been cut for a long time.

Nearby, there was a spinning wheel used for making thread, idle since he fell ill and now covered in dust. When asked about his illness, he replied, "I don't know."

"Have you had a medical check-up?" I inquired. "I went to the Nawalpur Hospital once, but I haven't been able to afford to go back. So, I haven't had any further check-ups," he said. "What's wrong with you?" I asked again, curious. "I often get dizzy," he answered briefly.

He introduced himself as 'System', a name given to him by his party. In the past, he was a section commander of the then Maoist Army and now lives permanently in Hattikhor by building a small shelter and purchasing a plot of land with Rs. 500,000 provided after the PLA adjustment. Originally, he was from Rolpa.

BK fought battles in Khara, Holeri, Chitrebhanjhyag and other places as a Maoist combatant for many years. He nearly lost his life in a battle in Palpa. Despite risking his life for the party, he now lives in misery, as he did not failed to maintain relation with the party outfit.

He said, "I love my party, but no one from the party has ever come to inquire about me. Even my fellow combatants who fought alongside me are no longer associated with the party."

Next to BK's house is the home of Dal Bahadur Nepali, another Maoist combatant, from Parbat. He has been in Saudi Arabia for the last three years leaving the house to his son and wife.

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Nepal-India JSC meeting reviews bilateral power trade, project implementation status

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The 11th meeting of the Joint Steering Committee on Power Sector Cooperation (JSC), co-chaired by Gopal Prasad Sigdel, Secretary (Energy), Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation and Pankaj Agarwal, Secretary, Ministry of Power, Government of India concluding in Chitwan on Friday reviewed the bilateral power sector cooperation between Nepal and India.

The meeting held after the signing of the Agreement on Long-Term Power Trade between India and Nepal on January 4, also reviewed the power trade and the implementation of hydropower projects and transmission lines.

According to a statement issued by the Embassy of India in Katmandu, progress made in various bilateral committees, including Joint Technical Team (JTT), was also discussed in the Chitwan meeting.

The meeting approved the modalities of cross-border power trade through 132 kV and below transmission lines. "This assumes special significance as three new 132 kV lines i.e. second circuit of Raxaul (Bihar, India)-Parwanipur (Nepal), second circuit of Kataiya (Bihar, India)-Kusaha (Nepal) and New Nautanwa (Uttar Pradesh, India)-Mainhiya (Nepal) which were jointly inaugurated by the External Affairs Minister of India and the Minister of Foreign Affairs of Nepal on January 4. These lines add about 200 MW transmission strength enhancing the overall transmission capacity between India and Nepal to 1400 MW," read the statement. Further, the

Nautanwa-Mainhiya transmission line is the first connection between Nepal and the state of Uttar Pradesh in India.

The two countries also agreed to hold the first meeting of the Joint Hydro Development Committee (JHDC) soon.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation said that Nepal and India have agreed mainly on eight issues to facilitate the exchange of electricity by enhancing the capacity of cross-border transmission lines between the two countries.

In a separate statement issued on Saturday, the Ministry said that the two sides agreed to increase the capacity of the Dhalkebar-Muzaffar cross-border transmission line, which is operated as a first cross-border transmission line, to 1000 MW from its existing capacity of 800 MW.

The two countries also decided to conduct a study through a Joint Technical Team (JTT) to determine the capacity of electricity that can be exchanged from the Dhalkebar-Sitamarhi 400 kV transmission line being constructed by Dhalkebar-Muzaffarpur and SJVN Arun-3 Power Development Company Pvt Ltd (SAPDC).



Similarly, it has been agreed to conduct a study through JTT on possible options for exporting electricity up to 200 MW from Tanakpur-Mahendranagar 132 kV power transmission line or other high voltage capacity transmission line.

Similarly, the meeting approved the modalities prepared by the Central Electricity Authority of India in coordination with the Nepal Electricity Authority and other agencies of India regarding the import and export of electricity between the two countries using the transmission system of the neighbouring state of India from Nepal during the rainy season through the existing transmission line of 132 kV capacity and below.

The JSC meeting instructed the JWG to finalise the investment modality to complete the construction of two more 400 kV cross-border transmission lines—Inarawa-Purniya and New Lumki (Dodohara)-Bareli transmission line between Nepal-India by 2027/28 and 2028/29 respectively.

To export 40 megawatts of electricity from Nepal to Bangladesh using India's transmission system, according to India's electricity import-export guidelines, Nepal Electricity Authority, India's NTPC Electricity Trade Corporation and Bangladesh's Power Development Board discussed the theoretical aspects of making a tripartite agreement soon.

Discussions have also been held in principle on having a separate tripartite agreement as per the Power Import and Export Guidelines of India, among NEA, the NTPC Vidhyut Vyapar Nigam of India and the Power Development Board of Bangladesh for the export of 40 megawatts electricity from Nepal to Bangladesh by using India's transmission system.

According to the ministry, JTT has been instructed to study more high-voltage level transmission lines required for importing and exporting electricity between Nepal and India.

Visiting Power Secretary Pankaj Agarwal also called on Minister for Energy, Water Resources and Irrigation of Nepal Shakti Bahadur Basnet before the JSC.

The two sides agreed to continue the discussions on the subject and decided to meet soon for the next sessions of the JWG/JSC meetings to be organised by the Indian side, read the statement of the Indian Embassy.

SC ORDERS NAC NOT TO DISCRIMINATE AGAINST CABIN CREW

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The Supreme Court has issued an interim order directing the Nepal Airlines Corporation (NAC) to not engage in discriminatory practices regarding perks and facilities for its cabin crew. In a decision rendered today by a single bench led by Judge Til Prasad Shrestha, the NAC management has been asked not to take any actions leading to discrimination against cabin crew in the allocation of facilities.

Senior advocates, including Dr. Chandrakant Gyawali, Ananta Raj Luintel, Kirtinath Sharma Poudel, Leeladhar Upadhyay, Pratibha Upreti, and Bishal Thapa, represented the petitioners in court. The order prohibits the NAC from terminating contracts, taking adverse actions, or intervening in facilities for cabin crew based on their appointment status.

On January 3, the entire cabin crew, numbering 135, filed a petition with the Supreme Court, citing injustice and discrimination in the provision of facilities. The defendants named in the petition include the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers, the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, and the NAC.

The cabin crew alleges that the NAC has implemented discriminatory policies against them, treating them as second-class individuals in violation of the law. They specifically challenge the provision allowing retirement of cabin crew at the age of 40, termination at any time with one month's compensation, appointment on a contractual basis throughout their service, and deprivation of gratuity.

Price of cardamom increases threefold

RSS
Ilam, Jan. 7

The price of cardamom has increased by threefold this season, bringing happiness to the farmers. Cardamom is now being sold at the highest price in the past four years. Trader Jeevan Pandey said that the price of cardamom has increased by almost three times more than last year. The price was Rs 28,000 last year but good quality of cardamom is now being sold at Rs 85,000 per quintal.

According to Pandey, the price of cardamom has increased this year because there is not enough cardamom as per its demand in the international market. Biren Shereng of Suryodaya municipality-1 has cultivated cardamom in an area of about 100 ropani of land. He said 27 to 30 metric tons of cardamom is produced annually giving savings of at least one million rupees.

The farmers of Ilam have started to increase their income after the improvement of cardamom with the use of modern farming system. This year, 1,325 metric tons of cardamom has been produced in the district. This is 7.96 percent more than the previous year. According to Agriculture Knowledge Centre, Ilam, the cardamom has



been produced with plantation in 1,753 hectares of land.

According to Runa Khadka, an employee of the Centre, only 1,215.26 metric tons of cardamom was produced last year when it was cultivated in 1,755 hectares. Though cardamom plantations have decreased, production and productivity have increased this year. He said that the productivity per hectare was 0.69 per hectare last year and increased to 0.75 per hectare in the current year.

In Ilam, cardamom is grown in all the 10 local levels including six rural municipalities and four municipalities. However, it is more extensive in Maijogmai and Sandakpur rural municipalities. Cardamom is grown at an altitude of 700 to 2100 meters above sea level.

WCP Nepal-AIB South Asia Conference kicks off

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

A two-day ' WCP Nepal-AIB South Asia Conference, 2024' commenced here today. The event jointly organised by the World Trade Organisation (WTO) Chairs Programme Nepal and Kathmandu University is themed 'Global Trade and South Asia: Competitiveness, Value Chains and ESG'.

Addressing the event, KU's Registrar Professor Achyut Wagle advised Nepal to adopt a specific commerce policy, especially considering its transition to a middle-income category.

As he suggested, Nepal should promote good production along with forward and backward linkages to compete in the global market.

Similarly, underling the need of formulating advanced foreign trade policies, Professor S Raghunath, the AIB-SAC Executive Board Chair, hoped for conference's role in this regard.

He highlighted global inter-dependency for an easy supplies chain, seeking an equal participation and contribution in the supply chain. He underscored the importance of utilizing innovations and intellectual rights to promote locally produced products.

Secretary at the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies, Narayan Prasad Sharma Duwadee, pledged to consider and implement research-based suggestions to bridge policy-level gaps and maintain a balanced foreign trade. He stressed the need for diverse expertise in crafting effective policies, particularly as Nepal strategically manages the challenges associated with its graduation to a developing country.

As Nepal strives to counter the potential loss of facilities following its graduation to a developing nation, Secretary Duwadee advocated for building a competitive market through domestic production to advance towards achieving the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

In his virtual address to the event, Ambassador of Nepal, Permanent Mission to the UN, Ram Prasad Subedi described foreign trade as an engine of development and prosperity. He echoed the significant role that South Asia plays in the world market. Ambassador Subedi pressed for the diversification of products and markets to address Nepal's high trade deficit.

Ambassador Subedi said various levels of discussions are being held at the United Nations for continuation of the duty-free and quota-free facilities Nepal and Bangladesh have been presently getting in the trade sector, even after their graduation to the developing country status.

According to him, import management would be easier if capital could be formed. He pointed out the need of making timely changes to the commerce policy of Nepal.

World Trade Organisation (WTO) Deputy Director General, Xiangchen Zhang, said works on capacity building are underway with different sectors and levels for facilitating in the global trade. Referring to the changes taking place in the world trade scenario in recent days, he expressed commitment to take initiatives for the continuation of the trade facilities in the trade with the least developed countries. He stressed that the international community itself should take seriously the issues related to climate change and reducing environmental risks.

Kathmandu University Vice Chancellor Dr Bhola Thapa maintained that the trade dimensions are changing at the regional and the world market as well and this is affecting more the countries like Nepal which have small economy and are dependent on imports. Efforts from all sides are needed to address this problem, he added.

Stating that Nepal's export side is extremely weak and the country has not been able to take adequate benefit from the WTO facilities, Vice Chancellor Thapa expressed the belief that research and mutual discussions at this international conference will contribute toward making better policies.

Indian Institute of Foreign Trade, Kolkata Campus chief professor K Rangarajan said that South Asia has not been able to take appropriate benefit in the trade sector despite having high demographic dividend.

Noting that South Asia has been facing various challenges in the regional and world trade, he said the countries of the region should take seriously the possibilities of taking the production from this region to the world market through the maximum use of innovative technologies.

General Secretary of the Association of Indian Universities, Dr Pankaj Mittal opined that inter-country linkages can be maintained by means of various academic studies.

More than 60 experts, researchers and academicians from seven various countries are attending the conference. Research papers on multiple topics will be presented and discussed in the two-day conference.

IPPAN welcomes long-term power trade agreement, calls for full opening of PPA

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN) has welcomed the long-term electricity trade agreement signed between Nepal and India to export 10,000 megawatts of electricity in the next 10 years.

Speaking at a press conference on Sunday, President of IPPAN Ganesh Karki expressed his belief that the private sector of Nepal can also benefit greatly from the long-term electricity trade agreement signed between Nepal and India during Nepal visit of Minister for External Affairs of India Dr. S. Jaishankar on January 4 and 5.

He said that the long-term electricity trade agreement, which will allow 10,000 megawatts of electricity to be exported to India every day in the next 10 years, is historic and welcome. Since 1971, electricity has been exchanged between Nepal and India, and a Power Trade Agreement (PTA) was signed in 2014. Based on the same agreement, up to 500 megawatts of electricity is being exported to India for a short period of time from Nepal.

He said that the private sector would also contribute significantly to the export of 10,000 megawatts of electricity. In the current fiscal year, electricity



PHOTO: TRN

IPPAN president Ganesh Karki and members in a press meet in Kathmandu on Sunday.

worth more than Rs. 15 billion was exported from Nepal to India, and a large part of it was hydropower projects built by the private sector.

Along with this agreement, the Power Purchase Agreement (PPA) which is currently being held by the Nepal Electricity Authority should be fully opened and licenses should be given to the private sector for electricity export, said the IPPAN. It said that the banks and financial institutions should increase investment in energy, and the government should announce more concessions for energy production. It demanded that the government should be more active and move immediately to solve the administrative and procedural problems. President Karki said that the agreement would create important opportunities in Nepal's energy development and open more doors. He said, "It is impossible to export so much electricity without the involvement of the private sector. The private sector is also ready to achieve the goal of electricity export."

NMA should be autonomous institution

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

Former presidents of Nepal Mountain Academy have expressed dissatisfaction over the decision of the government to merge the NMA into the Nepal Academy of Tourism and Hotel Management (NATHM).

The former presidents of the NMA held a press conference here on Saturday to express the opinion that it is not appropriate to merge the two institutes with different objectives. It will have a negative impact on the communities, stakeholders, and students of the mountaineering and adventure tourism sector, they said.

They expressed regret with the decision to merge the two institutes despite repeatedly speaking to the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation against it. They have claimed that if the decision is implemented the future of around 300 students will be in a limbo.

They appealed to all related government agencies to develop the NMA as a laboratory to study and research the mountainous region and instead develop it as an autonomous institution.

On the occasion, the former president and executive director of NMA Lakpa Phuti Sherpa recalled that the Academy played an important role in the management of education related to mountain climbing, and held the view that the merger of the two institutes will affect the development and promotion of the mountain climbing sector.

Another former president of the Academy, Prem Kumar Shrestha, said that the Academy has an important role in protecting the mountains of Nepal and claimed that the merger would not be compatible as the roles of the two institutes are different.

According to NAM, 33 undergraduate students of the Academy have successfully carried out study and research along with climbing of the 6,470 meter high Mera Peak, 16 post-graduate students have studied the 6,126 meter high Chulu Peak, and 15 students have successfully climbed the 6,190-meter Labuche Peak along with study and research.

Likewise, nine graduate level students have climbed 7,100 meters high Mt. Himlung and 28 undergraduate students have climbed Thorang mountain with a height of 6,144 meters, while carrying out study and research on it.

The Nepal Mountain Academy was established in 2002 under the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation. It provides academic courses affiliated with the Faculty of Management, Tribhuvan University.

Community schools collecting fees against constitutional provision

BY ARJUN KAFLE
Syangja. Jan. 7

Article 31 of The Constitution of Nepal states that every citizen shall have the right to get compulsory and free education up to the secondary level from the state, but even the model community schools in Syangja district have been found charging fees on different headings violating the constitutional provision.

Currently, about 1350 students are studying at Tribhuwan Aadarsha Namuna Secondary School in Putalibazaar Municipality-1.

The school has charged Rs. 600 more than the registration fee prescribed by the Examination Board.

The school has charged Rs. 2,000 to issue character certificates for the students.

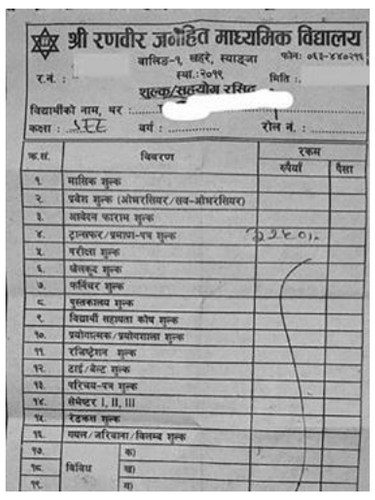
Students are taught in both English and Nepali medium at Tribhuwan Aadarsha Namuna School. The students of grade four are compelled to pay Rs. 300 and students of grade 10 are compelled to pay Rs. 600 as a monthly fee.

Mukti Prasad Regmi, Headmaster of the school, said that the school has a quota for only 29 teachers, but now 68 teachers are working in the school.

Due to the weak financial condition of the school, the school is forced to collect monthly fees from the students to pay the additional teachers.

Regmi said, "Although it is against the law to collect fees from the students, we have discussed with parents and have collected fees with the consent of the concerned parents to run the school smoothly"

Dahathum Secondary School of Bhirkot Municipality has charged Rs. 6 000 to issue School Leaving Certificates, to avoid the expense, the poor parents are admitting their wards to the same school after SEE.


श्री रणवीर जनहित माध्यमिक विद्यालय
बालिङ-९, खाडे, स्याङ्जा फोन: ०६३-४१०२१९
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२.	प्रवेश शुल्क (ओभरसियर/सव-ओभरसियर)		
३.	आवेदन फाराम शुल्क		
४.	ट्रान्सफर/प्रमाण-पत्र शुल्क	2200/-	
५.	परीक्षा शुल्क		
६.	खेलकुद शुल्क		
७.	फर्निचर शुल्क		
८.	पुस्तकालय शुल्क		
९.	विद्यार्थी सहायता कोष शुल्क		
१०.	प्रयोगात्मक/प्रयोगशाला शुल्क		
११.	रजिष्ट्रेशन शुल्क		
१२.	टाई/बेल्ट शुल्क		
१३.	परिचय-पत्र शुल्क		
१४.	सेमेष्टर I, II, III		
१५.	रेडक्रस शुल्क		
१६.	यातायात/जरिवाना/विलम्ब शुल्क		
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The admission fee is waived for the students who joined the same school after passing the SEE examination," said Shyam Kaji Adhikari, the Chairman of Ward No. 2.

Kalika Secondary School of Putalibazaar Municipality-13 also charges Rs. 1,000 as SEE registration fee and students studying in English medium are obliged to pay Rs. 650 as a monthly fee.

The model school of Waling Municipality, Ranabir Janhit Secondary School, has charged Rs 3,250 to issue a character certificate.

Most schools have charged Rs. 1,000 as a registration fee and an additional Rs.1,000 as an examination fee.

The local government and the District Education Unit have remained silent on these malpractices going on in the pretext of English medium and character certificates.

Bishwa Raj Acharya, the head of the District Education Coordination Unit, said that the local body was more responsible for the fee and that the office could not do anything regarding the collection of the fees.

Two killed, three injured in accidents

RSS
Baniyani (Jhapa), Jan. 7

Two persons have died while three others were injured in separate road accidents that took place in the district last night. One person died when a motorcycle went out of control near Jhilimili Bridge in Bhadrapur municipality-4 last night, and one person died and two others were injured when a passenger bus hit a motorcycle at Charpane Chowk in Birtamode municipality-2 the same evening.

Motorcycle rider Dhanapati Pathak, 31, and Lekhnath Dahal, 28, from from Kachankewal municipality-2 were injured when the motorcycle (Pra. 1-01-013Pa 9607) went out of control and hit the pillar on the side of the Jhilimili bridge in Bhadrapur municpality-4. Of them, pillion rider Dahal died while undergoing treatment at Omsai Pathibhara Hospital, Bhadrapur while Pathak is still undergoing treatment at the same hospital.

In the accident, Raviratna Sitaula,59, of Kankai-5 and Sagar Majhi of Bahradashi rural municipality-7 who were pillion riding were injured.

Similarly, Toyanath Upreti of Kankai Municipality-8, died when the motorcycle (Me. 1 Pa 7248) he was riding was hit by a passenger bus (Pra. 1-01-002Ba. 0149), Police Inspector Nawaraj Neupane of District Traffic Office Jhapa said.

In the accident, Raviratna Sitaula,59, of Kankai-5 and Sagar Majhi of Bahradashi rural municipality-7 who were pillion riding were injured. Both are undergoing treatment at Birta City Hospital, Biratmode. The driver of the bus has been detained and further investigation is underway.

Sudurpashchim PA to elect committee chairs on Wednesday



BY PRAKASH BIKRAM SHAH
Dhangadhi, Jan. 7

The election of the chairpersons for the four parliamentary committees of the Sudurpashchim Province Assembly is scheduled for January 10. According to a notice published by Provincial Assembly Secretary Dev Bahadur Bogati on Sunday, the nomination of the candidates will take place on January 9.

The election was initially scheduled for September 29 last year but was postponed at the last minute.

The Sudurpashchim Provincial Assembly comprises four parliamentary committees -- Legislation and Provincial Affairs Committee, the Public Accounts Committee, the Economic Development and Natural Resources Committee and the Social Development Committee.

Among these four, the opposition party will lead the Public Accounts Committee. Following the death of Prithvi Bahadur Singh, elected from Bajhang Constituency 1 (A), the Assembly now has only 52 members.

RPP TO HOST TEA RECEPTION ON JANUARY 12

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The Rastriya Prajatantra Party (RPP) is to organize a greetings exchange and tea reception programme at local Bhrikutimandap on January 12 on the occasion of the 302nd Prithvi Jayanti (birth anniversary) and National Unity Day.

RPP spokesperson Mohan Shrestha said the President, the Prime Minister, leaders of various political parties, representatives of diplomatic missions, constitutional bodies and religious organisations, industrialists and businessmen, professionals, intellectuals, among others, have been invited to the programme.

He stated that the President and the Prime Minister will attend the tea reception to be organised in honour of the builder of the nation, Prithvi Narayan Shah, who contributed to building modern Nepal by unifying various principalities. The party will also garland the statue of the late King Prithvi Narayan Shah, the unifier of the nation, at Singha Durbar.

The party's provincial and local units have also been urged to celebrate Push 27 (January 12) as the National Unity Day by organising a variety of programmes as seminars and interactions highlighting the late king's personality and history, tea reception and illumination.

Karnali govt launches citizen health screening campaign

BY RAJU LAMICHHANE
Rukum Paschim, Jan. 7

The Karnali Province government has conducted a citizen health screening campaign to identify the health-related problems of the citizens.

The campaign was launched targeting Aathbiskot Municipality of Rukum Pashchim, Chaukune Rural Municipality and Birendranagar Municipality of Surkhet, and Humla.

Launching the health campaign programme, Rajkumar Sharma, the Chief Minister of the Karnali Province, said that the main motive of the campaign was to improve the health condition of the citizens.

Stating that non-communicable diseases are a health challenge in recent times, CM Sharma said that health tests had begun for their prevention.

CM Sharma informed that the campaign would be extended to all districts of Karnali Province. "The government is taking health services in the community in both promotional and curative ways.

Active manpower is necessary in the health sector for conducting health examinations and treatment as well as generating health awareness among the public," he added.

The provincial government is conducting various health programmes at the local level affected by the earthquake.


PHOTO: RAJU LAMICHHANE/TRN
Officials in a health screening campaign launching program.

CM Sharma mentioned that the provincial government was fulfilling its responsibility for search, rescue, treatment, relief and now reconstruction work after the devastation caused by the earthquake.

Dr Robin Khadka, Director of Karnali Province Health Directorate, informed that the campaign aimed at examining the health of citizens aged above 55 years.

"A five-year policy programme would be made based on the results obtained from the current health examination campaign. I believe that this campaign will help understand and improve the health condition of citizens aged above 55 years in this region," said Khadka.

Similarly, Chundamani Paudel, Chief Secretary of Karnali Provincial Government, said that the programme and budget had been allocated by giving priority to health.

"The government is trying to make the health services simpler and more convenient for the people of Karnali Province.

In the first phase, civil health examinations will be conducted in Rukum Paschim and Surkhet and in Humla in the second phase," added Paudel.

NEWS BRIEF

Quake-victim dies of cold

Jajarkot: Yet another earthquake victim in Jajarkot has died because of cold-induced pneumonia. The deceased has been identified as 58-year-old Karna Bahadur Bishwakarma, a resident of Bheri municipality-1, Rawatgaun. He was living under a tent braving the winter chill, and got infected with pneumonia.

Bishwakarma was taken to the district hospital for treatment. But the district hospital referred him to the provincial hospital Surkhet. His son Ruplal BK said that he died in the Provincial Hospital Surkhet while undergoing treatment.

A total of 36 earthquake victims died because of cold after an earthquake jolted Jajarkot and Rukum West on November 3, last year killing 154 people.

Picnic bus knocks one to death

Birtamode: At least one person was killed and two others were injured in a road accident in Charpane Chowk, Birtamod-2 in Jhapa. A bus with registration number Pra. 01-002 Kh-0149, which was returning from a picnic hit a motorcycle with registration Me 5 Pa 7248 on Saturday night.

When the motorcycle with three on it tried to overtake the bus, it hit the front part of the bus killing motorcycle rider 44-year-old Toyanath Upreti of Kanakai Municipality-8 on the spot.

Two pillion riders, Rabi Ratna Sitaula of Kankai-5 and Sagar Majhi of Barhadashi-7, were injured in the accident.

(TRN)

IGP Aryal inaugurates Tripura battalion office in Jumla

BY NETRA SHAHI
Jumla, Jan. 7

Inspector General of the Armed Police Force Nepal Raju Aryal inaugurated the newly constructed No. 33 Tripura battalion office in Jumla. IGP Ayal inaugurated the office building made at Lamra located in Tatopani Rural Municipality-5 of Jumla during a programme held on Sunday.

Speaking after the function, IGP Aryal instructed the Armed Police personnel to focus on facing and resolving increasing security challenges in the growing security threat around the world.

He said that he was blessed and happy to inaugurate No. 33 Battalion in Jumla of Karnali during his tenure and said that the Headquarters is positive to cater the resources for the Battalion.

He also promised that the No. 33 Battalion will be developed by making an action plan in terms of doing activities to protect Sinja civilisation and culture. He expressed his gratitude to the land owner, local government and concerned agencies, along with the entire team of APF of Jumla, for having succeeded in constructing the building here which had remained in a rented land and house.

IGP Aryal gave special thanks to the landowners for providing the land and directed the Battalion to make good use of their investment. Chetraj Joshi, chief of the battalion, presented the progress and financial report of the building construction in the inauguration programme. According to Joshi, the building was constructed at a cost of Rs. 40.52 million.

> The No. 33 Battalion will be developed by making an action plan in terms of doing activities to protect Sinja civilisation and culture.


PHOTO: NETRA SAHI/TRN
Inspector General of the Armed Police Force Nepal Raju Aryal inaugurated the newly constructed No. 33 Tripura battalion office in Jumla.

Locals of Lapche grapple with network problem


PHOTO: NETRA SAHI/TRN
Local hotel entrepreneur Kamal Kathayat with his equipment.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Jan. 7

Locals of Lapche in Sarkegad Rural Municipality-2, Humla district, are left with no option but to attach a wooden stick to their mobile phones to get connected with the mobile network.

Kamal Kathayat, a local, said that it was difficult to get a mobile network in the area. He said, "We need to attach our cell phone to a wooden stick to catch the network. For the past two years, locals have been using this method to get mobile network."

Kathayat has been operating a hotel business in Lapche, and has been providing communication service to customers applying the same process.

Additionally, due to the remoteness of the area, he has been offering motorcycle services to customers by managing motorbikes from Syaltadi and Sarkegad.

With recent improvements in road connectivity across the Karnali River, the hustle and bustle of people has increased significantly, but residents continue to face challenges connecting to the mobile networks.

Warrant/Notice issued by the High Court Patan Lalitpur to the following individual.

In relation to the application Writ No. 080-WO-0862 filed by the writ applicant Mr. Gokul Bahadur Rokaya against the opponent including you demanding to issue certiorari mandamus order and application Writ No. 080-WO-0911 filed by the writ applicant Mr. Gokul Bahadur Rokaya against the opponent including you demanding to issue certiorari mandamus order, this warrant/notice has been hereby issued according to the order of this Court dated 2080/09/18 BS (January 03, 2024 AD). Therefore, you are hereby noticed to submit your reply statement in writing by personally or through your power of attorney or representative pursuant to the laws within 15 (Fifteen) days except traveling period from the date of publication of this notice. Otherwise, shall be done pursuant to the laws. In addition, as the mentioned writ application is enlisted in the case list for discussing on the date 2080/09/25 BS (January 10, 2024 AD) for purpose of issuing interim order, it is also to inform you to attend on the discussion of presentation. **Particulars :**

2. Spectrlite UK Limited, One Fleet Place, Londaon, EC4M7WS.....1

Done it on Moday, 2080 Poush 23 BS (January 08, 2024 AD) with best regards.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Experience is simply the name
we give to our mistakes.
- Oscar Wilde

EDITORIAL

Beyond Remittance

Remittance now stands as the backbone of the nation's economy and has played a crucial role in supporting stabilisation and growth. Remittance earning constitutes approximately 25 per cent of the country's GDP over the past few decades. The rise in remittance inflow has led to a notable enhancement in foreign currency reserves during the previous fiscal year. These reserves are crucial for meeting development requirements and ensuring economic stability. The strength of economy is closely linked to foreign exchange reserves and its dwindling can have negative repercussions in foreign trade. The increased remittance inflow and reduced imports of luxury items have effectively curbed excessive foreign currency depletion. In the recent months, there has been a notable upswing in foreign currency reserves, balance of payments, current account, and remittance inflows which are positive signs for the economy. Simultaneously, the gradual decrease in bank interest rates and the increase in available liquidity within the banking sector have instilled a sense of optimism, suggesting that the country's economy is showing signs of recovery.

With the aim of encouraging migrant workers to send remittances through the formal channels, the central bank has made the policy arrangement to maintain an interest rate that is at least one per cent higher than the interest rate published by banks and financial institutions on deposits received from remittances. As per the NRB (Nepal Rastra Bank), remittances totaling Rs. 477.96 billion were received by Nepal in the initial four months of the current fiscal year. Furthermore, the gross foreign exchange reserves exhibited a growth of 10.2 per cent, reaching Rs. 1,696.78 billion in mid-November 2023 compared to Rs. 1,539.36 billion in mid-July 2023. Foreign exchange reserves held by the banking sector are deemed sufficient, covering approximately 13.6 months of prospective merchandise imports and 11.3 months of combined merchandise and services imports.

In the short term, remittances can contribute to achieving macroeconomic objectives, including reducing current account deficits, increasing income levels, breaking out of poverty cycles, and safeguarding the public from negative economic shocks. But the nation cannot make it a long term goal because relying on remittance alone can be counterproductive in a long run. Thus it is essential for the government to strategically invest remittance funds in productive sectors like agriculture, hydropower, tourism as well as other areas that generate employment and help boost prosperity. Rather than solely relying on the influx of remittances, the government should prioritise the expansion of industries, achieving self-sufficiency in agriculture, generating domestic job opportunities, and fostering the growth of the tourism sector.

A holistic approach to economic development is necessary, as sustained dependence on remittances alone is not a viable long-term solution for the country. Inflow of remittance might be affected by crisis times such as pandemic, recession and war. At the same time our migrant workers most of the time are unskilled labourers selling their labour in very demanding and often risky working conditions. It is important for policymakers to strike a balance between harnessing the positive aspects of remittances and channelling those earnings into productive sectors for long-term economic stability and growth. For the sustainable development of the country we should be able to cash in the labour of our youth in our own country by creating job opportunities, so that our labour force can contribute to our economic development as per need of the nation without going out of the country.

Joys Of Outdoor Adventure

BISHALYA GAUTAM

People who work long hours throughout the week often wonder what they will do on Saturdays. Usually, it's either finishing up errands that remain, spending time with family, or traveling somewhere to unwind after a stressful week at work. In contrast to previous years, local tourist destinations, particularly in the Kathmandu Valley, are overrun with visitors on weekends and other holidays. People are starting to understand how important it is to get out from the valley for an hour or two in order to decompress and visit locations that hold cultural, historical, architectural, or natural significance.

One wonders about the sudden surge of people on weekends at significant locations. There is a lot of contributing factors on why individuals spend their leisure time visiting nearby tourist attractions. The abundance of freely accessible and transparent information about various locations on social media platforms could be one of the primary causes. Many online celebrities, or even regular users, who are among the first few tourists to visit a noteworthy location, are able to spread the word about it and maximise its tourism potential, thereby promoting the location and securing a spot on many people's weekend itinerary.

Despite its flaws, social media helps these previously overlooked locations of exceptional beauty and importance, since it not only raises awareness of the area but also strengthens the local economy. People in their middle ages who work are mostly visiting these areas to capture the view and experience that so many others have captured on camera, as evidenced by the numerous social media platforms.

Furthermore, the access to these prestigious locations may result from a number of factors. Notably, there are lots of options of public transportation that suit different tastes, and there are continuous initiatives to build new and expand existing roadways. The road network under construction is evidence of the dedication to improving connectivity. The majority of people choose two-wheelers as their primary means of transportation, demonstrating the popular preference for quick and adaptable travel. Still, a portion of the population chooses the practicality of four-wheelers, so they have access to a variety of modes of transportation. The network of carefully groomed, well-paved roads winds its way through the rolling hills that surround the valley, highlighting the picturesque drive there.

Furthermore, there's a chance that the alarmingly high levels of pollution in the valley are also a cause. The public has been experiencing increased levels of stress and exhaustion as a result of the demanding workloads they bear in addition to the constant exposure to ubiquitous pollution while traveling to and from work each day. Air pollution is a constant companion that has a noticeable negative impact on people's physical and mental health. For the typical worker, negotiating through thick haze and navigating the busy, polluted thoroughfares has become a taxing habit. Thus, a vacation from this never ending conflict could be immensely relieving and revitalising, giving much-needed relaxation from the never-ending fight against environmental problems.

A day away from these taxing conditions might greatly reduce the built-up tension and fatigue, providing the working public with a valuable opportunity to replenish and rejuvenate amid the rigorous demands of their everyday lives.

Europe's New Outlook On Migrants



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

At a time when the world begins to witness gradual changes in the traditional world order, much of Europe is turning—according to its own definition—rightist. Until a few years ago, it vociferously extolled the virtues of multiculturalism. Strange as it might seem, several states in Europe are, of late, having a rethink about the cultural universalism they tried adjusting to but robustly prescribed it to others. Significant political quarters in Denmark, France, Germany, the Netherlands and Sweden sound resigned to retracing their steps in the wake of a series of disturbing developments. They have unambiguously expressed consternations about "unpalatable" and "incompatible" conditions created by the influx of immigrants and refugees.

Italy's Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni sums up her concern: "Islam is incompatible with Europe." Head scarves worn by Muslim women are among the causes of their concern. At the turn of the century, no such reservation was tossed up. Undeclared segregation is another issue.The Dutch complain against migrants from other parts of the world, who make it difficult in distinguishing who is who and from which culture. They echoed the changing mood by enabling an openly anti-immigrant Geert Wilders' Party of Freedom to secure 37 seats in the recent elections. Wilders' is the single-largest grouping in a house of 150 members, with the nearest rival credited with only 25 seats.

'Parallel societies'

Sweden's former Prime Minister Eva Magdalena Andersson despairs over what she saw as "parallel societies and segregation" threatening national social harmony. Denmark offers money to refugees mostly from Muslim countries, to return home. If the latter fail to respond promptly, they are forcibly deported without any ceremony and incentives. Listed as one of the most peaceful nations, Swedes are complaining that migrants have contributed to making hospital waiting time long and one of the worst in Europe. Some complain against falling educational standards. Finland, too, is having second thoughts over their policy on immigrants.

Muslims in France are not allowed to wear hijab (head scarves) at educational and other institutions as they represent religious semiotics that do not match with the secular social characteristic the Fifth Republic envisages. Burqa, a long dress that covers women from head to ankles, is also disallowed at schools, campuses and other institutions. When France prohibited head scarves, some sections in the dominant class were worried about the implications the regulation would have on the country's secular credentials. But the ban has stuck firm.

The Dutch government, too, followed the French course. Some sections of the dominant population targets 750,000 Muslims as a threat to their "core values". The most candid comments came from the Dutch political party led by Wilders. He did not mince words when he clearly and loudly voiced for packing off migrants who refused to "integrate" in mainstream Dutchness. Wilders has round-the-clock police protection following death threats from Muslim groups enraged by his views on their community. Concerned over what is seen as risks to their "core values", politicians and intellectuals brandish the argument: "Protecting Christian values and culture isn't wrong." Many find relief over the subject at long last being debated. The latest electoral gains Wilders' party garnered reiterated the strength gathered by views targeting the religious minority, whose members are reported to be involved in increased inconvenience for the dominant section. Muslim youth are blamed for the rise in crime rate also.

> A new European model for social integration seems to be gradually emerging, though contradictory to what the dominant groups previously extolled and nudged others to adopt.

They also generate jealousy in the dominant community because of the success many immigrant families achieve through prosperity earned by sheer hard work at educational institutions and work place. An atmosphere of distrust is growing, as migrants are seen as either perpetrators or victims of disproportionately larger percentage of crimes. A new European model for social integration seems to be gradually emerging, though contradictory to what the dominant groups previously extolled and nudged others to adopt. Some of the countries, which regularly figure in the list of the best governed, have installed rightist parties in power. Elsewhere, organisations with rightist lenses captain coalition cabinets with their own leaders in prime ministerial chairs.

The EU is planning major changes in asylum laws. Millions of Germans are reported to have regretted their former Chancellor Angela Merkel's liberal policy of admitting half a million migrants to Germany in the "crisis year" when the borders were thrown upon to receive refugees in hundreds of thousands. Merkel's policy was to attract labour shortage and to meet skilled foreign hands, so that the number of non-European Union workers increased by 60,000 a year. Now, most Germans are dissatisfied with the policy. Poland's leaders have been stressing on their desire to preserve Polish way of life.

Reverse gear

Strange as it might sound to some, an increasing number of countries that erstwhile proactively promoted multiculturalism are backtracking. They apply the reverse gear so that their dominant identities do not get sidelined or become indistinguishable from those of other communities. To them, multiculturalism won't work—a conclusion that would have disconcerted them until recently. At least seven European states now ban facial veil and a robe-like garment that covers a woman from head to ankles. Latest reports suggest that the Dutch leader Geert is drawing increasing appreciation in as many as 20 European states.

Illegal immigrants are being deported to the African state of Rwanda and other locations in return for billions of dollars for the relatively lucrative but not much appreciated service for the rich Western governments. The reverse outlook is gaining ground not only in Europe but also in other industrially rich countries. A recent survey conducted by Pew Research Centre indicated that 63 per cent of respondents in the United States considered the news media portraying black people in negative terms. This contrasted with the 28 per cent of the respondents, who thought that the general coverage of such news was equal for all racial groups. The digest of universalism spawned earlier does not disturb the sensibilities of economically advanced lands that until the 1990s employed terms like "melting pot" and "assimilation" in self-congratulation before flushing with "universalism". The ensuing months should speak more specifically on what is in store on this score.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Tourist Arrival Boosts Industry's Confidence



Ballav Dahal

The year 2023 brought a lot of glimmer of hope to Nepal's tourism industry as the nation witnessed a strong recovery in the number of tourists despite numerous national and international factors, including a global economic slump, the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and Israel hostility. The country was able to welcome a bit more than one million foreign tourists last year, creating much confidence among travel trade people. In 2022, a total of 614,148 foreign tourists came to the country. However, tourist arrivals did not reach pre-COVID-19 levels. In 2019, the country received about 1.19 million visitors while tourist arrivals stood at 1.17 million in the preceding year. Nepal as well as various other tourist destinations worldwide have started recording a steady recovery in visitor arrivals since the beginning of 2022 following a record-low in the number of international arrivals in 2020 and 2021due to the spread of COVID-19.

Contribution

Recognising a significant contribution of the tourism sector for the national economy, the government has come up with a plan to mark the period between 2023 and 2033 as Tourism Decade, targeting to attract a million tourists in the initial year. With this decade-long initiative, the government aims to give a boost to the potential but delicate tourism industry. It is needless to mention that tourism is one of key sources of foreign exchange reserves. The multifaceted industry creates many jobs as well. Its significance lies in the fact that it helps several other economic sectors grow sustainably. Though tourism in Nepal is mostly a seasonal business, it contributes towards retaining youths within the country because it provides them with job opportunities. Under the Tourism Decade plan, the nation aims at bringing in two million tourists this year. Extra efforts must be made to achieve this ambitious target.

According to the data unveiled by the Nepal Tourism Board (NTB), Nepal received nearly 1,015,000 foreign tourists last year. This figure shows that tourist arrivals recovered by about 95.76 per cent from pre-pandemic scenario. Neighbouring India has continued to remain the biggest tourist source market for Nepal because of physical proximity and an easy access. Cultural similarities and open borders are also attributed to higher tourist arrivals from the southern neighbour. In 2023, Indian arrivals increased to 319,936 from 254,150 in 2019. This data indicates an encouraging rise of 25.88 per cent. However, the figure does not include those Indian travellers who entered Nepal through various land routes. A lot of pilgrims from different parts of India come to Nepal every year in order to visit numerous pilgrimage sites such as Pashupatinath Temple, Lumbini, Janakpur and Muktinath.

With the Indian economy recording a robust growth rate, travellers from India are among high spenders. But it seems that Nepal is failing to make them spend much because of a lack of an effective policy. Each of Indian visitors is allowed to bring with them less than INR 25,000 in cash while travelling to Nepal at one time. Since this policy is not favourable for the development of our tourism industry, the Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) and other responsible authorities must revise it immediately. This has not only caused huge loss to our economy but also created inconvenience to those tourists willing to spend more during their trips.

> It is necessary for the government bodies as well as other travel trade stakeholders to focus on lengthening the stay of tourists and increase their spending.

Another difficulty facing Indian tourists is that they cannot make payments online or use ATM. While the two governments have already agreed to operate cross-country online payment gateways, no significant progress has so far been made in this connection. The relevant bodies must follow up on this so as to bring the cross-country digital transaction system into operation at the earliest. Besides, the Nepal government needs to facilitate Indian visitors interested in coming to the country over land routes. At present, they have to go through unnecessary inspections. Their vehicles are also checked many times. Besides, sacred pilgrimage sites such as Janakpur, Lumbini and Muktinath can be marriage destinations for many Indian youths. So, the government needs to adopt a suitable policy to attract such groups.

The United States (US) became the second largest tourist generating market for Nepal in 2023. Even though Nepal and the US are faraway physically, the Himalayan nation hosts a lot of American tourists. Last year, a total of 100, 357 Americans experienced their trips to Nepal. In 2019, the number of US tourists visiting Nepal stood at 93,241 while the figure was 49,830 in 2013. This shows that the number of American tourists nearly doubled over the past one decade. Americans are mostly interested in trekking and cultural tours. More holidaymakers from the US are expected to visit Nepal this year. However, the US has recently issued a travel advisory suggesting the possibility of peaceful political demonstrations escalating into violence in Nepal. Since Nepal's political situation is normal, the US travel advisory is unlikely to have any negative implications for our tourism industry.

Lucrative packages

But it is worrying that the Chinese market shrank for Nepal in 2023. The country lured only 60,878 Chinese tourists last year as compared to 169,543 in 2019. Chinese arrivals fell considerably last year despite resumption of flights from various cities in China to Kathmandu. Nepal's tour operators need to offer more lucrative packages in order to tap the vast Chinese market. However, the Bangladeshi market appears to be better. Last year, more than 32,000 Bangladeshi travellers came to Nepal. In 2019, the figure was 25,849.

In 2022, average length of stay of tourists decreased to 13.1 days from 15.5 days in 2021. It is natural that average tourist spending also falls with the shortening of their stay. Last year, the average spending of tourists dropped to US$40 per day from US$48 per day in the preceding year. Besides attracting more tourists from across the world, it is necessary for the government bodies as well as other travel trade stakeholders to focus on lengthening the stay of tourists and increase their spending. This can be possible only through developing better tourism infrastructures and diversifying tourism activities. Proper policy incentives are also equally essential for bolstering tourism.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 8, 1974

Smuggled Cloths Seized

Kathmandu, Jan. 7: The Zonal Commissioner's office raided the godown of Dwarika Prasad Sagarmal of Gaur and seized cloths worth about one hundred thousand rupees, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Strictly Enforce Land Discipline



I am writing this to express my concern after reading the news story titled *"Breach of lane rule nullifies Naya Baneshwor's upgraded intersection"* published in this daily on Jan. 7. The recent renovation of Naya Baneshwor intersection, a collaboration between the Government of Nepal and JICA, holds promise for efficient urban transport.

While the urban transport management system is a positive move, the intended benefits are jeopardised by the persistent lack of lane discipline. The 200-meter divider on Maitighar-Tinkune Highway, designed for right turns, is often occupied by vehicles heading straight, causing unnecessary delays.

Effective measures to penalise violators and raise awareness about the importance of lane discipline are crucial. Land discipline saves lives by keeping road accidents at bay and makes navigating roads easier. It is essential for authorities, particularly the Kathmandu Valley Traffic Police, to enforce stricter measures to ensure the success of this initiative and promote safer urban transportation.

Rukmina Lamsal
New Baneshwor

TAILPIECE

The construction foreman ordered one of his men to dig a hole 8 feet deep. But after the job was done, the boss returned and explained an error had been made and the hole wouldn't be needed. "Fill 'er up," he ordered the worker.

The worker did as he'd been told. But he ran into a problem. He couldn't get all the dirt packed back into the hole without leaving a mound on top. He went to the office and explained his problem.

"Honestly!" the foreman snorted. "The kind of help I get these days! There's obviously only one thing to do. You'll have to dig that hole deeper!"

Voters cast ballots in Bangladesh election amid opposition boycott

AP
Dhaka, Jan. 7

Voters in Bangladesh cast their ballots Sunday as polls opened in a parliamentary election fraught with violence and a boycott from the main opposition party, paving the way for Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina and her Awami League to seize a fourth consecutive term.

Authorities said at least 18 arson attacks were reported across the country since late Friday, with 10 of them targeting polling places. Four people died Friday in an arson attack on a passenger train heading toward the capital, Dhaka. The incidents have intensified tensions ahead of the parliamentary elections that the opposition Bangladesh Nationalist Party and its allied groups said they would shun.

Campaigning in the South Asian nation of 169 million has been marred with violence as at least 15 people have been killed in recent months. Hostilities reached a boiling point in late October after a massive rally in Dhaka by the BNP saw clashes with police.

On Sunday morning, Hasina and her daughter voted amid tight security at Dhaka City College, as other citizens lined up outside to cast their ballots.

The 76-year-old Hasina, the country's longest-serving leader and one of its most consequential, is widely expected to be reelected for a fifth overall term.

But a victory would come with a deeply contentious political landscape. The vote, like previous elections, has been defined by the bitter rivalry between Hasina's Awami League and



PHOTO: AP
Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina casts her vote in Dhaka, Bangladesh, Sunday, Jan. 7, 2024.

BNP, led by former Premier Khaleda Zia, who is ailing and under house arrest on corruption charges, which her supporters claim are politically motivated.

The two women ran the country alternatively for many years, cementing a feud that has since polarized the country's politics and fuelled violence around elections.

This year's vote raised questions over the credibility of the polls when there are no major challengers to take on the incumbent.

Nearly halfway into voting hours, the turnout was 18.5%, according to the Election Commission Secretary Jahangir Alam.

Badshah Mia, 55, a rickshaw puller in Dhaka told The Associated Press that he wouldn't vote, given the limited choices, adding that the atmosphere didn't exude that of "a fair election."

Sakibul Hasan Chowdhury, a businessman, felt the same: "There is no opposition and no candidate of my choice. So how would I benefit from voting?"

Meanwhile, Habibur Rahman, 56, who owns a small business said he was voting for the ruling party candidate in his constituency but added that there didn't seem to be much crowd or a turnout.

Affan Bin Imran, a 19-year-old student, said he felt proud and excited to be able to cast his vote for the first time.

Critics and rights groups say the vote follows a troubling pattern, where the past two elections held under Hasina were sullied by allegations of vote-rigging — which authorities have denied — and another boycott by opposition parties.

The government has rejected a monthslong demand by the BNP to have a neutral caretaker government administer Sunday's vote.

The government has defended the election, saying 27 parties and 404 independent candidates are participating. But with scores of those independent candidates from the Awami League itself, and mostly smaller opposition parties in the race, analysts say Hasina's win is near inevitable.

Michael Kugelman, director of the South Asia Institute at the Wilson Centre, said none of those contesting would be able to mount much of a challenge to Hasina's party.

The vote has also been called into question by accusations of a sweeping crackdown against the BNP. The party says about 20,000 of their members were jailed ahead of the vote on trumped-up charges, but the government disputed the figures and denied that arrests were made due to political leanings, saying the numbers of those arrested were between 2,000-3,000. The country's law minister in an interview with the BBC said 10,000 were likely arrested.

Abdul Moyeen Khan, a former minister and BNP leader, said the spate of arrests forced him and scores of other party members to go into hiding for weeks until candidacy nominations were halted. "It was the only way we could ensure our safety and carry on raising our voice (against the government)" he said.

Hasina is credited with transforming the economy of a young nation born out of war and making its garment sector one of the world's most competitive. Her supporters say she has staved off military coups and neutralized the threat of Islamist militancy. And internationally, she's helped raise Bangladesh's profile as a nation capable of doing business and maintaining diplomatic ties with countries often at odds with each other, like India and China.

Yet her critics say her rise has risked turning Bangladesh into becoming a one-party state where democracy is under threat, as emboldened government agencies increasingly use oppressive tools to mute critics, shrink press freedoms and restrict civil society.

Blinken meets Jordan king to prevent Gaza war spread



PHOTO: AP
U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken, left, meets with Jordanian Foreign Minister Ayman Safadi in Amman, Jordan Sunday, Jan. 7, 2024.

AP
Jordan, Jan. 7

U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken met Sunday with Jordan's king and foreign minister and visited a World Food Program warehouse in Amman as he pressed ahead with an urgent Middle East diplomatic mission to prevent Israel's war against Hamas in Gaza from spreading.

On his fourth visit to the region in three months, Blinken stressed the need for Israel to adjust its military operations to reduce civilian casualties and significantly boost the amount of humanitarian aid reaching Gaza while highlighting the importance of preparing detailed plans for the post-conflict future of the territory, which has been decimated by intensive Israeli airstrikes and ground offensives.

After a day of talks with Turkish and Greek leaders in Istanbul and Crete, Blinken met Sunday with Jordan's King Abdullah II and Foreign Minister Ayman Safadi seeking buy-in for U.S. efforts to tamp down resurgent fears that the three-month-old war could engulf the region, ramp up aid deliveries to Gaza and prepare for the eventual end of hostilities.

King Abdullah II "warned of the catastrophic repercussions" of the war in Gaza while calling on the U.S. to press for an immediate cease-fire, a statement by the Royal Court said.

Jordan and other Arab states have been highly critical of Israel's actions and have eschewed public support for long-term planning, arguing that the fighting must end before such discussions can begin.

Israel signals wrapping up major combat in Gaza

AP
Jerusalem, Jan. 7

The Israeli military signalled that it has wrapped up major combat in northern Gaza, saying it has completed dismantling Hamas' military infrastructure there, as the war against the militant group entered its fourth month Sunday.

The military did not address troop deployments in northern Gaza going forward. Its spokesman, Rear Adm. Daniel Hagari, said late Saturday that forces would "continue to deepen the achievement" there, strengthen defences along the Israel-Gaza border fence, and focus on the central and southern parts of the territory.

The announcement came ahead of a visit to Israel by U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken. Biden administration officials, including Blinken, have repeatedly urged Israel to wind down its blistering air and ground offensive in Gaza and shift to more targeted attacks against Hamas leaders to prevent harm to Palestinian civilians.

In recent weeks, Israel had already been scaling back its military assault in northern Gaza and pressing its offensive in the territory's south, where most of Gaza's 2.3 million Palestinians are being squeezed into smaller areas in a humanitarian disaster while being pounded by Israeli airstrikes.

The war was triggered by Hamas' Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel in which the militants killed about 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and took some 250 people hostage.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has insisted the war will not end until the objectives of eliminating Hamas, getting Israel's hostages returned and ensuring that Gaza won't be a threat to Israel are met.

Israel's retaliation by air, land and sea has killed more than 22,700 Palestinians and wounded more than 58,000, according to the Health Ministry in Hamas-run Gaza. The count of the dead does not distinguish between combatants and civilians. Health officials say about two-thirds of those killed have been women and minors. Israel blames Hamas for the heavy civilian casualties because the group operates in heavily populated residential areas.

On Sunday, officials at Nasser Hospital in the southern city of Khan Younis received the bodies of 18 people, including 12 children, who were killed in an Israeli strike late Saturday. More than 50 people were injured in the strike on a home in the Khan Younis refugee camp, which was set up decades ago to house refugees from the 1948 Mideast war over Israel's creation and morphed into a neighbourhood of the city.

Snow hinders rescue and aid deliveries to quake victims in Japan

AP
Japan, Jan. 7

Rescue teams worked through snow to deliver supplies to isolated hamlets, six days after a powerful earthquake hit western Japan, killing at least 128 people. Heavy snowfall expected in Ishikawa Prefecture later Sunday and through the night added to the urgency.

After Monday's 7.6 magnitude temblor, 195 people were still unaccounted for, a slight decrease from the more than 200 reported earlier, and 560 people were injured. Hundreds of aftershocks have followed, rattling Noto Peninsula, where the quakes are centred.

Taiyo Matsushita walked three hours through mud to reach a supermarket in Wajima city to buy food and other supplies for his family. The home where he lives with his wife and four children, and about 20 nearby homes, are among the more than a dozen communities cut off by landslides.

Power was out, and in a matter of hours, they couldn't even use their cell phones, he told Jiji Press.

"We want everyone to know help isn't coming to some places," Matsushita was quoted as saying by Jiji Press. "We feel such an attachment to this community. But when I think about my children, it's hard to imagine we can keep living here."

Late Saturday, a woman in her 90s was rescued from a crumbled home in Suzu, Ishikawa Prefecture, after 124 hours trapped in the rubble. She was welcomed by shouts of encouragement, although the darkness and a long blue sheet of plastic blocked her from view. Chances for survival greatly diminish after the first 72 hours.



PHOTO: AP
Police officers conduct a search operation in a snow at a burnt market in Wajima, Ishikawa prefecture, Japan Sunday, Jan. 7, 2024.

Of the deaths, 69 were in Wajima, 38 in Suzu, 11 in Anamizu, and the rest in smaller numbers spread among four towns. Firefighters and other disaster officials were trying to get to nine people believed to be buried under collapsed houses in Anamizu, Japanese media reports said.

Ishikawa officials say 1,370 homes were completely or partially destroyed. Many of the houses in that western coastal region of the main island are aging and wooden. Cars lay tossed on cracked, bumpy roads. Snow blanketed the debris and highways. Wires dangled from lopsided poles.

The more than 30,000 people who evacuated to schools, auditoriums and community facilities slept on cold floors.

PRISM

Unusual type of algae is coming close to beach

California: An unusual type of algae is coming close to shore in California, leading to a phenomenon known as bioluminescent -- or glowing -- waves.

Visitors to Orange County beaches this week reported spotting the glowing blue waves in multiple locations during nighttime hours, and charter boat services have been offering special after dark tours of the illuminated waters.

The phenomenon is caused by an algae known as lingulodinium polydra, which is known for its bioluminescence, or natural glowing, when it reacts to being moved by the water.

The glowing waves correspond with the red tide, an algae bloom that can cause the waters to appear red, brown or orange during the day due to the presence of the algae.

Wood likely from 19th century ship found

Maryland: Maryland State Parks officials said an unusual piece of driftwood that washed up on a state park beach was identified as a deck timber from a 19th century ship.

Officials wrote in a Facebook post that the 14.5-foot piece of timber washed up at Assateague State Park in December and Maryland Historic Trust experts were consulted to try to determine what it was.

"It appears that this timber is from the mid-to-late 1800s and is mostly-likely a deck timber with some other parts attached to it," the post said.

(AP)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1828 – The Democratic Party of the United States is organized.
1973 – Watergate scandal: The trial of seven men accused of illegal entry into Democratic Party headquarters at Watergate begins.
1977 – Three bombs explode in Moscow, Russia, Soviet Union, within 37 minutes, killing seven. The bombings are attributed to an Armenian separatist group.
1982 – Breakup of the Bell System: In the United States, AT&T agrees to divest itself of twenty-two subdivisions.
2002 – President of the United States George W. Bush signs into law the No Child Left Behind Act.
2016 – West Air Sweden Flight 294 crashes near the Swedish reservoir of Akkajaure; both pilots, the only people on board, are killed.
2020 – Ukraine International Airlines Flight 752 crashes immediately after takeoff at Tehran Imam Khomeini International Airport; all 176 on board are killed. The plane was shot down by an Iranian anti-aircraft missile.

US sees drop in illegal border crossings after Mexico enforcement

AP
Texas, Jan. 7

Daniel Bermudez's family had fled Venezuela and was headed to the U.S. to seek asylum when the freight train they were riding through Mexico was stopped by immigration officials.

His wife tried to explain that her family had permission to go to the U.S. Instead, they flew her to Mexico's southern border as part of a surge of enforcement actions that U.S. officials say have contributed to a sharp drop in illegal border crossings.

In addition to forcing migrants from trains, Mexico also resumed flying and busing them to the southern part of the country and started flying some home to Venezuela.

Even if temporary, the decrease in illegal crossings is welcome news for the White House.

President Joe Biden's administration is locked in talks with Senate negotiators over restricting asylum and $110 billion in aid for Ukraine and Israel hangs in the balance.

Bermudez said his wife became separated from her family when she talked to authorities as he gathered his stepchild and their belongings. He wanted to run, but his wife said they shouldn't because they had followed procedure by making an appointment with U.S. immigration authorities.



PHOTO: AP
A guardsman stands watch at the U.S.-Mexico border, Wednesday, Jan. 3, 2024, in Eagle Pass, Texas.

"I told her, `Don't trust them. Let's go into the brush,'" Bermudez said, adding that other migrants had fled. He recalled her telling him, "Why are they sending us back if we have an appointment?"

Last week, Bermudez, his stepchild and two other relatives were waiting for her at a shelter in the Mexican border town of Piedras Negras as she took a bus back in hopes of still making the date.

Mexico's immigration agency sent at least 22 flights from its border region with the U.S. to southern cities during the last 10 days of December, according to Witness at the Border, an advocacy group that tracks flight data. Most were from Piedras Negras, which is across the border from Eagle Pass, Texas.

Mexico also ran two removal flights to Venezuela with 329 migrants. The stretch was punctuated by U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken's visit to Mexico City on Dec. 28 to confront unprecedented crossings to the United States.

Mexican President Andrés Manuel López Obrador said a financial shortfall that had led the immigration agency to suspend deportations and other operations was resolved. He did not offer details.

Arrests for illegal crossings into the U.S. from Mexico fell to about 2,500 on Monday, down from more than 10,000 on several days in December, according to U.S. authorities. In the Border Patrol's busiest area, arrests totalled 13,800 during the seven-day period ending Friday, down 29% from 19,400 two weeks earlier, according to Tucson, Arizona, sector chief John Modlin.

The drop led U.S. Customs and Border Protection to reopen the port of entry in Lukeville, Arizona, on Thursday after a month-long closure on the most direct route from Phoenix to its nearest beaches. The U.S. also restored operations at Eagle Pass and three other locations.

Merchants in Eagle Pass, a city of about 30,000 people, saw sales take "a major hit" while a bridge was closed to vehicle traffic so border agents could be reassigned to help process migrants, Maverick County Judge Ramsey English Cantu said.

Last month, CBP resumed freight crossings in Eagle Pass and El Paso, Texas, after a five-day shutdown that U.S. officials said was a response to as many as 1,000 migrants riding atop a single train through Mexico before trying to walk across the border.

In Piedras Negras on Thursday, Casa del Migrante housed about 200 migrants, down from as high as 1,500 recently.

NHRC EXPRESSES CONCERN OVER DEATH IN SARLAHI

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) has said that its serious attention was drawn to the incident involving the death of Jaishankar Sah during a protest after argument over the issue of upgrading a health centre in Barahathawa, Sarlahi.

Issuing a press statement on Sunday, NHRC spokesperson Dr. Tikaram Pokharel informed that the Madhes Province Office of the NHRC was monitoring the incident.

During a preliminary monitoring by the NHRC, it was found that Sah, 30, was killed in a dispute regarding the issue of upgrading the health centre.

Police personnel and locals were also injured, prompting the family of the deceased and the public to continue demonstrations demanding justice and the local administration to issue curfew frequently. Sah's body was still at the incident site.

The Commission has received information that the government has formed a committee to probe the incident.

The NHRC also urged the federal, province and local governments to investigate the incident impartially and independently and bring the culprit of the incident under the purview of legal action, to arrange for proper relief and compensation to the family of the deceased, free treatment of the injured, and not to repeat such kinds of incidents.

In addition, the Commission also requested the agitating parties to find a solution to the problem through dialogue.



PHOTO: RSS

Visitors enjoy boating on Barhakune Lake around Barahakshetra temple in Sewar of Ghorahi Sub-Metropolitan City-13 in Dang district.

Banke National Park charts plan to lure visitors

BY SIRAJ KHAN
Nepalgunj, Jan. 7

Banke National Park, the country's youngest national park established for tiger conservation, has formulated a roadmap to lure more local and foreign tourists.

According to Manoj Kumar Shah, the Chief Conservation Officer of Banke National Park (BaNP), a strategic plan to attract tourists has been prepared and put into action a decade after the establishment of the park.

He said, "We are transforming BaNP into a park that people are eager to visit, and we expect a substantial increase in the number of tourists."

Shah said that efforts are underway to work as per the roadmap, focusing on enhancing tourism infrastructure and improving facilities provided by homestays. Boating in the Rapti River, jungle safaris, footpaths, and elephant safaris are all aimed at attracting more visitors.

He revealed plans to immediately implement initiatives for the improvement and management of tourist activities, forest trails, water facilities and grassy fields starting from the upcoming fiscal year.



The National Park has consistently worked to increase the number of tigers and their prey species, organise grasslands and construct water ponds and fire lines. Along with tigers, there are plenty of rare four-horned Antelopes in the park.

According to the park office, the BaNP boasts over 422 species of animals, encompassing 34 species of mammals, of which 11 are considered rare.

The park is also home to 300 species of birds, including 50 rare species, 24 reptiles, including two rare species, and 55 species of fish, featuring five rare species. The park spans across the Tarai, Bhawar, and Chure regions, encompassing all three types of climates and vegetation. The Chure Hills within the park offer significant potential for tourist activities.

Feasibility studies have been conducted for organising activities such as boating, viewing the sunset and rafting in the Rapti River in the Agaia area of the park. In support of these initiatives, various skill-based training programmess have been carried out for the locals.

Likewise, the park has developed packages for elephant safari, jungle safari, and trekking in the vicinity of Ovari. A view tower has been constructed in Giddenichaur, to observe the forest area, providing opportunities for walking and jungle safari.

Krishna Lal Chaudhary, the pioneer in developing the Gabar area connected to the park as a tourist destination, said that around 25,000 domestic and international tourists visit the Gabar area annually. He said, "Efforts to connect these areas to the park are going on."

The Gabar Valley is being developed as a homestay area. A blend of Tharu, Mugali and Humli cultures can be found in Gabar.

As there is a park area around it, this area is becoming a destination for domestic tourists for hiking and observing wildlife.

POLICE EXPOSE HASHISH MIXED MUFFIN TRADE

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

Police have cracked down on a hashish mixed muffin business in the Kathmandu Valley.

The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) of Nepal Police exposed the business after the police detained one youth involved in the illegal trading of narcotics from Kathmandu.

The NCB arrested Bishan Manandhar from Ghattekulo in the capital on Sunday. Chakra Raj Joshi, spokesperson of the Bureau, informed that he was conducting business targeting youth online to sell his marijuana mixed cakes.

SP Joshi said that it was found that Manandhar was making an account through Instagram, using drugs and making muffins and other cakes for selling in the market to his target groups and consumers.

SP Joshi said that after receiving information about the business, the team of the Bureau arrested Manandhar from his own house. He said that various drugs were recovered from his house. It has been revealed from the investigation that Manandhar had been making various types of marijuana-laced cakes at his home and delivering them online for the past one year.

Similarly, during the investigation, the Bureau also found a menu of cakes prepared by mixing marijuana, which Manandhar sells and by means of digital connection. Some of the names of marijuana-laced cakes include epiphany bread, happy cups, buzz light year, nasty candy and others. According to the police, necessary investigations are being conducted against him under the Narcotics Control Act, 1977.

HOSPITAL CONSTRUCTION UNCERTAIN

BY DIL BAHADUR SINGH
Doti Jan. 7

Construction of a hospital to be built in at Saraswati Nagar in Jorayal Rural Municipality-3 of Doti district has not started yet even five months after the contract deal expired.

According to Chandra Singh AD, Information Officer of the Jorayal Rural Municipality, an agreement was signed between the Rural Municipality and Rajendra Nirman Seva on August 3, 2021, for the construction of a 15-bed hospital and complete the construction within two years. It has been five months since more than the expiration period.

The construction company had taken an advance of Rs. 19 million on January 24, 2022.

The estimated cost of the hospital building is Rs 150 million. The Integrated Health Infrastructure Development Programme under the Ministry of Health and Population of the Federal Government provided financial support for the construction of the hospital building.

Presence in CC...

In the meeting, members Sumana Shrestha, Arjun Narsingh KC, Sovita Gautam, Nisha Dangi, Prem Suwal, Sushila Thing and Raghu Pant tried to garner the support of the meeting in favour of the amendment proposal by submitting their arguments that their respective amendments were correct from their sides.

The government has presented a bill to amend the procedures related to calling the council meeting, conducting the meeting, and the quorum required for the meeting.

In the meeting, member Arjun Narsingh KC said that the council has recently turned into a council of 'political division' instead of a Constitutional Council.

Ruling parties share candidacy,...

After Koirala, who is not in the parliamentary board, left the meeting venue, and other leaders were busy discussing the issue, party president Deuba again called Dr. Koirala and the two were holding meeting by the time this news was filed.

But other ruling parties including the CPN (Maoist Centre) fianalised their candidates. A meeting of the office bearers of the CPN (Maoist Centre) held at the official residence of Prime Minister and the party Chairman Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' in Baluwatar picked the names of six candidates.

After the meeting, party secretary Devendra Paudel informed that Champa Devi Karki from Koshi Province, Shrikrishna Adhikari from Bagmati Province, Manarupa Sharma from Gandaki Province, Jhakku Subedi from Lumbini Province, Bishnu Bishwakarma from Karnali Province and Renu Chand from Sudurpaschim Province are the candidates from the Maoist Centre.

The CPN (Unified Socialist) entrusted the responsibility to party chairman Madhav Kumar Nepal, vice chairman Rajendra Pandey and general secretary Ghanashyam Bhusal to finalise the names of the party candidates. A meeting of the party secretariat held on Sunday decided to do so, informed spokesperson Jagannath Khatiwada.

The Janata Samajwadi party has picked Puja Chaudhary (Rautahat) as its candidate. A meeting of the party's executive committee picked her name, said party spokesperson Manis Suman after the meeting.

The main opposition party CPN-UML finalised the names of all its 19 candidates at a meeting of the party secretariat on Sunday.

After the meeting, party general secretary Shankar Pokharel informed that Rukmini Koirala (Sunsari) and Parshuram Adhikari (Bhojpur) will be the candidates in Koshi Province. Usha Devi Tharuni (Parsa) and Dr. Arjun Kumar Singh Rajput (Mahottari) are picked from the Madhes Province and Rochkumari Chaulagai (Dolakha) and Trilochan Nirmal Poudel (Chitwan) from Bagmati. Likewise, Bibek Devkota (Kathmandu) is picked from the disabled minorities in Bagmati and Dhruba Raj Bishwakarma (Dhading) as the Dalit representative.

In Gandaki Province, Yamanda Devkota (Gorkha), Chakra Bahadur Parajuli (Syangja) and Hemandra Sherchan (Mustang) will be contesting the NA election from the CPN-UML.

In Lumbini Province, Tulsa Kumari KC (Dang) and Jhapendra Bahadur Gharti Chhetri (Palpa) are picked while in Karnali Province, Bimala Kumari Shahi (Humla), Dilli Prasad Bhatta (Mugu) and Hikmat BK (Dailekh) are UML candidates.

In Sudurpashchim Province, Sabitra Devi Ghimire (Kailali), Ishwari Prasad Kharel (Kanchanpur) and Ram Chandra Joshi (Kailali) will contest the election from the UML.

The Rastriya Prajatantra Party also finalised its nine candidates.

A meeting of the party work execution committee held on Sunday finalised the names, informed party spokesperson Mohan Shrestha.

The party said Uddav Paudel for Koshi, Hemjung Gurung, Nanu Nagarkoti, Bharatmani Bhatta and Purna Bahadur Bishwokarma are candidates from Bagmati Province.

It also picked Gaumaya Shrestha and Rom Bahadur Bhanadri for Gandaki and Niranjan Thapa and Bijaya Laxmi Singh for Lumbini provinces.

Agro tool expo sees transaction booking worth Rs. 60 million

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Pokhara, Jan. 7

Agricultural machinery and equipment worth Rs. 60 million were booked during the first province-level Agri-Mechinery Exhibition 2080 organised by the Nepal Agricultural Machinery Association (NAMEA) in Pokhara.

About 30,000 people observed the three-day expo which concluded on Sunday. The expo featured more than 70 stalls of 60 companies involved in production, sales, maintenance, training and application of agricultural machinery and equipment. The organisers said that the first province-level expo also witnessed a transaction of machines worth Rs. 5.5 million. "The event has been a successful venture," said Krishna Sharma, President of the NAMEA.

On the third day of the exhibition, Sunday alone, machinery worth about Rs. 30 million were booked, while agricultural tools, machinery and agricultural materials worth more than 1.5 million were sold on the same day.

The event was supported by the Agricultural Infrastructure Development and Agricultural Mechanisation Promotion Centre, Directorate of Agricultural Development, Gandaki and Pokhara Metropolitan City. Speaking at the closing programme of the event, Mayor of Pokhara Metropolitan City, Dhana Raj Acharya, expressed his commitment to allocating the budget in the field of agriculture as per the need.

Former PLA members left in state...

Sarita, Nepali's wife, runs a chatpate (Nepali snacks comprising a mixture of instant noodles and vegetables with a sour taste) stall. She hesitated to speak to me and when asked about her husband's party-given name, she got angry and refused to answer. Meanwhile, Nepali's son said that his father was no longer in the party. Likewise, Dil Maya Magarati, wife of Maoist combatant Shyam Lal Magarati, also expressed dissatisfaction with the party. She informed that her husband had been actively involved as a Maoist combatant for an extended period. She said that her husband who had been severely sick had just recovered after spending Rs. 300,000 in treatment.

She said, "My husband is now old, illiterate and almost died due to sickness. We have abandoned the party since our personal suffering remained with us despite the numerous rallies and struggles. While the leaders have climbed up the political ladder, we are still where we used to be."

Another combatant Saroj BK of Dang has also a house in the settlement. But, it was locked when I arrived on Saturday noon. I tried to update myself about the situation of the former Maoist combatants in the settlement but found none besides Kumar BK. Locals nearby informed that some combatants had gone abroad, some had migrated to the hills, while others present were visiting church and engaged in prayers at the time.

In the first Constituent Assembly elections after the peace process, the CPN-Maoist was the largest party. Though the PLA army was integrated into the Nepali Army, many combatants were left out of the process due to illiteracy. Those left out combatants were key in conducting the election. Since the party had not shown any interest in those left out combatants, it resulted in a reduction of the parliamentary seats in the second Constituent Assembly election.

Meanwhile, in-charge of CPN (Maoist Centre) Nawalpur Amar Tamu acknowledged that the local party leadership had been unable to pay attention to the left out combatants. He said, "I am not fully aware of the situation of the left out combatants in Hattikhor as I was appointed as an in-charge in the area only recently. I will discuss the issue with the party and will also draw its attention to the issue."

Government of Nepal
Ministry of Health & Population
Department of Health Services
Management Division
Pachali, Teku, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notice for Price bid open

Date of Notice: 8 January 2024

Pursuant to clause 31(4) and (5) of Public Procurement Regulation 2064, this is to notify all the bidders that the following substantially responsive technical bidder has been selected for further evaluation as per the Invitation for Bids published on The Rising Nepal and DOHS decides to open the price bid on **23 January 2024 on 12:00** Hr.

RFB No.	Notice Published Date	Successful Bidders Name and Address
DOHS/G/ICB-16/ IDA/2080-81 (Procurement of Portable USG machine	20 September 2023	**M/S Max Meditech System Pvt. Ltd.** New Baneshwor Kathmandu

Biratnagar women learn to play Naumati Panche Baja

BY NAWARAJ KATTLE
Biratnagar, Jan. 7



Durga Devi Dahal, a resident of Biratnagar-3, is joyfully reviving the city's cultural heritage by playing 'Narsinga' amidst the prevailing modern music trend.

A 30-day training on 'Naumati Panche Baja' (Nepali traditional musical instruments) organised by Biratnagar Metropolitan City has fulfilled 50-year-old Dahal's desire to play the traditional musical instrument amidst the floods of modern musical instruments.

Similarly, Keshav Kumari Acharya from Biratnagar-4 is also embracing the art of playing traditional musical instruments. "It's late, but Biratnagar has also provided women with an opportunity of commercial Pancha Baja training, Saraswati Khanal, a resident of Biratnagar-3, said.

"We also want to get out of the house and do something," she added. The Biratnagar Metropolitan City allocated a budget of Rs. 500,000 to organise the training for 32 women to master the art of playing Naumati Panche Baja.

Led by trainers, including Chanda Paudel from Itahari-4, the first 15 days were focused on foundational skills.

In the remaining 15 days, the trainees, like Khanal, practiced playing Panche Baja with melody and rhythm.

Tara Katuwal, a participant in the training, expressed her determination to break gender norms by playing traditional instruments like Jhyamta, Mujura and Narsingha with a focus on auspicious tunes.

Basu Bahadur Basnet, Chairman of Ward No-3 in Biratnagar Metropolitan City, said that the Metropolitan City has taken the initiative to organise Naumati Baja training specifically for women, making arrangements within the budget.

The ward office has also invested Rs. 200,000 in procuring the necessary instruments and materials, he added.

Post-training, the management responsibility will transition to the Hamro Jyestha Nagarik Hatemalo Sewa Samaj, ensuring continued cultural development.

Jibendra Ghimire, president of the society, emphasised the inclusive vision of breaking caste and community barriers in playing Naumati Baja, aiming to place women at the forefront of cultural development.

Shilpa Nirala Karki, Deputy Mayor of Biratnagar Metropolitan City, said that the budget allocation for the training aligned with the demands of women, viewing Naumati Baja as a tool for empowering and professionally advancing women.

Trainer Chanda Paudel shared her experience, noting that playing Panche Baja at weddings can earn up to Rs. 60,000, reflecting the changing dynamics and growing appreciation for cultural traditions. Panche Baja consists of musical instruments such as Damaha, Jhyali, Tyamko, Dholak, Sahanai, Karnal, and Narsinga.

Among these, Sahanai and Damaha are represented twice.

Naumati Baja, a composition requiring nine instrumentalists, involves playing the Sahanai and Narsinga, large and small Damaha, Dholak, Tyamko, and a mix of Jhyamta and Mujura in harmony.

Judith Light and 'Last of Us' actors are first-time winners at Emmy Awards

AP
Los Angeles, Jan. 7



Judith Light from "Poker Face" and Nick Offerman and Storm Reid from "The Last of Us" were winners at Saturday night's Creative Arts Emmy Awards on a night when the theme was first-time Emmys for actors of all ages.

Light, 74, took her first Emmy in a nearly 50-year television career for playing a 1960s radical hiding out in a retirement home on an episode of " Poker Face," the Peacock comedy-mystery series starring Natasha Lyonne. The star of the 1980s and 1990s sitcom "Who's The Boss?", Light had been nominated four times previously, including twice for her acting on "Transparent."

"I've been in the business a long time, and this is quite a gift," Light said backstage.

Offerman, 53, won his first Emmy in four nominations, taking best guest actor in a drama series for his role as an angry survivalist who ends up in a tender gay relationship on "The Last of Us," the HBO video game adaptation about a fungal apocalypse that won a leading eight Emmys on Saturday.

Offerman's 20-year-old castmate Reid, currently a college student at nearby USC, won best guest actress in a drama in her first nomination for a similar episode, a flashback in the form of a tragic teen love story between her and best lead actress nominee Bella Ramsey.

Offerman praised "The Last of Us" for its "decency and inclusivity" and Reid said she was grateful for its "representation of young, queer Black women."

Sam Richardson, 39, won his own first Emmy for playing a billionaire soccer enthusiast from Ghana on " Ted Lasso," the Apple TV+ series that is the year's most nominated comedy with 21 nods. He had been nominated once previously for the same role.

The two-part ceremony, where nearly 100 awards are handed out, mostly to less famous crew members and crafts people, began Saturday night and continues Sunday night. It's a precursor to the main Emmy ceremony that will air at 8 p.m. EST Jan. 15 on Fox, with "black-ish" star Anthony Anderson as host. Just like the main telecast, the Creative Arts Emmys arrive after a four-month delay because of Hollywood's writers and actors strikes.

Another 1980s and '90s sitcom star, Jasmine Guy of "A Different World," won her first Emmy on Saturday, for best actress in a short-form comedy or drama series for " Chronicles Of Jessica Wu." Tim Robinson won the same award on the actors' side for "I Think You Should Leave With Tim Robinson." It's his second Emmy for performing on the Netflix show.

Christian Oliver and his 2 daughters died in a plane crash

AP
Puerto Rico, Jan. 7



U.S. actor Christian Oliver and his two daughters died in a plane crash near a tiny private island in the eastern Caribbean, according to police in St. Vincent and the Grenadines.

The crash occurred Thursday just west of Petit Nevis island near Bequia as the plane headed for nearby St. Lucia, police said in a statement.

They identified the daughters as Madita Klepser, 10, and Annik Klepser, 12, adding that the pilot, Robert Sachs, also died.

It wasn't immediately clear what caused the crash, according to police.

Authorities said fishermen and divers in the area went to the crash site to help as the St. Vincent and Grenadines Coast Guard headed to the area.

"The selfless and brave acts of the fishermen and divers is very much appreciated," police said.

The 51-year-old actor born in Germany had dozens of crediting film and television roles, including in the 2008 film "Speed Racer" film and "The Good German," a 2006 World War II film by Steven Soderbergh that starred George Clooney and Cate Blanchett.

He appeared throughout season two of the 1990s series "Saved by the Bell: The New Class," playing a Swiss transfer student named Brian Keller.

Jodie Foster finds Gen Z 'Really Annoying' to work with

AGENCIES
New York, Jan. 7



Acclaimed actress-filmmakerJodie Foster said that Gen Z can be "really annoying" to work with.

The 61-year-old actress is a vocal supporter of the younger generation and does a lot of mentoring, she said she still finds Gen Z, usually referred to as those born between 1997 and 2012, frustrating to work with.

"They're really annoying, especially in the workplace. They're like, 'Nah, I'm not feeling it today, I'm gonna come in at 10.30 a.m.' Or, like, in emails, I'll tell them this is all grammatically incorrect, did you not check your spelling? And they're like, 'Why would I do that, isn't that kind of limiting?'" Foster told The Guardian.

Despite her irritation with some members of Gen Z, Foster has a close relationship with many, including non-binary star Bella Ramsey, 20, who Foster asked to introduce her at the Elle magazine Women in Hollywood celebration.

She said: "I reached out to Bella, because we'd never met, and said, 'I want you to introduce me at this thing', which is a wonderful event about actors and people in the movies, but is also very much a fashion thing.

Which means it's determining who represents us."

"They are very proud of themselves because they've got every ethnicity, and I'm like, yeah, but all the attendees are still wearing heels and eyelashes.

There are other ways of being a woman, and it's really important for people to see that.

And Bella, who gave the best speech, was wearing the most perfect suit, beautifully tailored, and a middle parting and no makeup." "I do a lot of reaching out to young actresses. I'm compelled. Because it was hard growing up," she added.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: New places are calling your name. This is a great day for impromptu or planned travel, as you're able to experience intriguing ways of life, unfamiliar foods, and fascinating people.

Taurus: The scales are balancing out. You've potentially been concerned about your relationship with someone close to you, or you might be worried about business or money matters -- regardless.

Gemini: Now is the time to ask for what you want. The issue may stem from being denied certain supportive measures or aid from others that you needed in the past -- or you may have been rejected for a job that you desperately wanted.

Cancer: You might find common ground with former enemies at any moment. There's potentially a coworker that you didn't get along with or a family member that wasn't interested in listening -- particular circumstances aside, you probably never expected.

Leo: New people in your network could seem to exemplify your ideal vibes. You may have previously been in friend groups where you were subjected to jealousy, stress, gossip, or other difficulties.

Virgo: Your family can lift you up when you're feeling let down. Others might have put you in a difficult situation that you needed to find your way out of, and now your family, biological.

Libra: What you say will impact your day. Now might be the time to mention anything that's on your heart, especially things that you wouldn't usually speak out loud. Honesty is encouraged for you.

Scorpio: Creativity could create a second source of revenue for you. You might have recently discovered a talent of yours with results everyone enjoys -- something that you could turn into a side hustle if you had the time and energy.

Sagittarius: You might be seeking forgiveness. It could be due to guilt regarding something that you did or said, as it may have happened in the heat of the moment and caught you or others off guard.

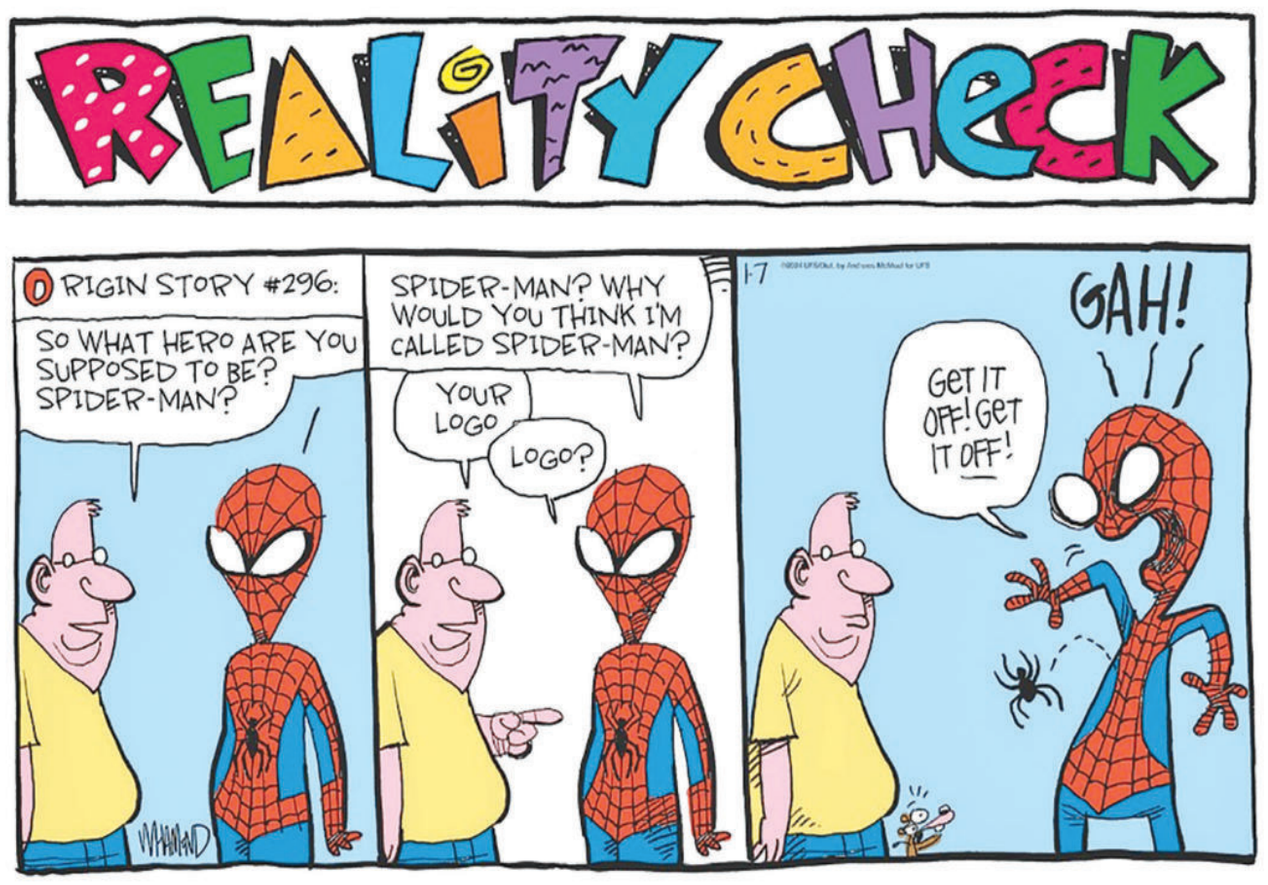
Capricorn: Spiritual healing can take place throughout the day. You might engage in some art therapy or focused meditation that allows you to feel more in tune with the universe, giving you renewed insight.

Aquarius: Your long-standing goals may finally be coming into view. Perhaps a lot of work went into these goals, though you saw no reward for a long while. At long last, you can make out a light at the end of the tunnel.

Pisces: You can show the world who you really are inside. This may cause people to feel jealous of the attention that you're getting from a project launch, community involvement, a new position at work.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



NSJF Pulsar Sports Award on Jan. 26



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The 20th edition of the NSJF Pulsar Sports Award, the most famous sports award of the country, has been scheduled for January 26, organisers informed.

The Nepal Sports Journalist Forum (NSJF) has joined hand with Hansraj Hulaschand and Company once again for the award programme.

"It has been 15 years that the NSJF has been coordinating with Hansraj Hulaschand and Company for the sports award. We are thankful for the company, its chairman Shekhar Golchha and the Golchha Group for their continuous support," said Durga Nath Subedi, president of NSJF.

Abhimanyu Golchha, director at Golchha Group, and Subedi signed in the agreement papers for the NSJF Pulsar Sports Award 2024 amidst a press conference at Royal Singi Hotel in Kathmandu on Sunday.

NSJF general secretary Prajwal Oli informed that athletes in nine categories will be honoured and the nomination list in five categories will be made public soon.

"Athletes will be awarded under best men player, best women player, best youth player, best coach and people's choice categories. The list of nominated players for the five categories will be disclosed within a couple of days," read a statement by the NSJF.

"Hansraj Hulaschand and Company will provide two Bajaj Pulsar NS250 and three Bajaj Pulsar NS160 for the winning players in the five categories," said Golchha.

According to the organisers, no nomination lists will be revealed for awards under lifetime, special, para-athlete and Asian Sports Journalist categories. "The winners for the four categories will be revealed on the day of the programme," the statement read.

The athletes will be adjudged under the basis of their performance during the award's reference period from mid-April 2022 to mid-April 2023.

NADAL OUT OF AUSTRALIAN OPEN WITH MUSCLE TEAR

AFP
Melbourne, Jan. 7

Spanish superstar Rafael Nadal on Sunday pulled out of the Australian Open with a "micro tear on a muscle" barely a week after making his comeback from a year-long injury absence, but said he remained positive.

The 37-year-old had been out of the game since injuring his hip at the 2023 Australian Open, undergoing surgery before making his comeback at the Brisbane International.

He won his opening two matches, but needed a medical timeout towards the end of his quarter-final loss to Jordan Thompson after feeling pain in his upper left thigh.

"During my last match in Brisbane I had a small problem on a muscle that as you know made me worried," he said on X, formerly known as Twitter.

"Once I got to Melbourne I have had the chance to make an MRI and I have micro tear on a muscle, not in the same part where I had the injury and that's good news.

"Right now I am not ready to compete at the maximum level of five-set matches. I'm flying back to Spain to see my doctor, get some treatment and rest."

Injuries have been a recurring theme of Nadal's record-breaking career, a painful by-product of his all-action, brutal-hitting style that has led to struggles with serious knee, wrist and foot problems.

The 22-time Grand Slam champion stressed in Brisbane that he did not come into the tournament expecting to win, and hinted that the Australian Open was coming too soon for him.

"I have worked very hard during the year for this comeback and as I always mentioned my goal is to be at my best level in three months," he said.

"Within the sad news for me for not being able to play in front of the amazing Melbourne crowds, this is not very bad news and we all remain positive with the evolution for the season."

Chelsea enter FA Cup with comfy win

AP
London, Jan. 7

Even while Chelsea is struggling in the English Premier League, its form in cup competitions could yet see it end the season with a trophy or two.



PHOTO: AP

Chelsea's Raheem Sterling celebrates after scoring his side's third goal during the FA Cup Third Round match against Preston North End in London.

With a place in the League Cup semifinals already, Chelsea advanced to the fourth round of the FA Cup on Saturday after pasting Preston North End 4-0.

That could give U.S. owners Todd Boehly and Clearlake Capital cause for optimism in a crisis-ridden run since their takeover in 2022.

At 10th in the league, Chelsea looks likely to miss out on qualifying for the Champions League for a second year in a row. But manager Mauricio Pochettino is finding joy in the domestic cups, extended against second-division Preston after Armando Broja, Thiago Silva, Raheem Sterling and Enzo Fernandez scored in a second-half rout at Stamford Bridge.

"The first half I was a little disappointed. We started so sloppy," Pochettino said. "I told the players at halftime we needed to increase the energy and match that of Preston. The second half was a completely different game. We dominated, created chances and deserved victory."

In the League Cup, Chelsea will face second-division Middlesbrough over two legs in the semifinals, and is favored to meet Liverpool or Fulham in the final.

But Pochettino will note how close Middlesbrough was to forcing a replay against Aston Villa before eventually losing 1-0 against the second-placed team in the Premier League.

Matty Cash scored an 87th-minute winner at Riverside Stadium.

As well as being an unlikely league title contender, Villa has reached the knockout stage of the Europa Conference League.

Alexander Isak scored twice as Newcastle won the first northeast derby in eight years against Sunderland 3-0 in front of a fervent crowd at the Stadium of Light. Dan Ballard's own goal gave Newcastle a first half lead.

Trailing at second-division Queens Park Rangers 2-0, Bournemouth was in danger of defeat. But Marcus Tavernier sparked a second-half comeback. Further goals from Kieffer Moore and Justin Kluivert sealed a 3-2 win.

Brighton was also behind to second division opposition after Jan Paul van Hecke's 16th-minute own goal at Stoke. Pervis Estupinan leveled for the Premier League team in first-half stoppage time and Lewis Dunk added another goal early in the second half.

Lewis Baker equalized for Stoke from the penalty spot, but two Joao Pedro goals completed a 4-2 win for Brighton.

There were no scares for Sheffield United, which picked up only its third win of the season in all competitions by beating fourth-division Gillingham 4-0.

Leicester, which won the cup in 2021, beat Millwall 3-2. The 2016 Premier League champion is enjoying an impressive season after being relegated from the top-flight last year. Leicester has a 10-point lead atop division two, and victory against Millwall was its 24th in 30 games in all competitions.

CLOSED CAMP FOR U19 WOMEN'S SAFF C'SHIP STARTS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 7

The All Nepal Football Association (ANFA) has started a closed camp to train players of the U19 national women's team for the SAFF U19 Women's Championship being held in Bangladesh from February 2 to 8.

According to ANFA, 35 players were called for the closed camp by head coach Bal Gopal Shaukhala from Friday.

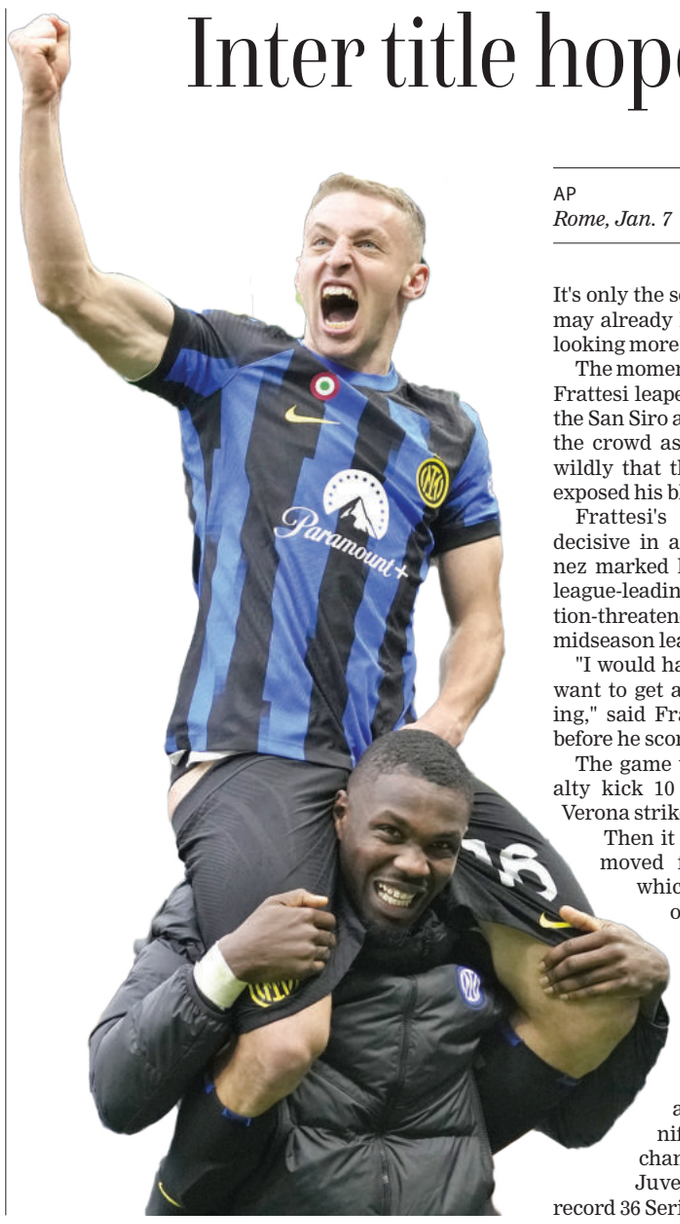
ANFA had selected new coaches for the team on January 3. Alongside Shaukhala as the Head Coach, Ganga Gurung and Shyam Sundar Singh were appointed as Assistant Coaches and Sailesh Karmacharya as the Goalkeeping Coach.

As per the list of the 35 players in the closed camp, four are goalkeepers, 13 defenders, nine mid-fielders and nine forwards.

The players were selected on the basis of selections conducted in the district, provincial and federal levels. ANFA had organised the central selection at the Satdobato-based ANFA Complex from January 3.

The district-level selection was held throughout the country in the year 2023 from December 17 to 22.

Inter title hopes rise in Serie A



AP
Rome, Jan. 7

It's only the season's midpoint and Inter Milan may already have its lasting image of what is looking more and more like a Serie A title run.

The moment came on Saturday when Davide Frattesi leaped on top of a yellow fence lining the San Siro and erupted in celebration toward the crowd as his teammates mobbed him so wildly that they pulled down his shorts and exposed his black underwear.

Frattesi's stoppage-time winner proved decisive in a frenetic finish, Lautaro Martinez marked his return from injury with his league-leading 16th goal, and Inter beat relegation-threatened Hellas Verona 2-1 to secure the midseason lead in Serie A.

"I would have done much worse but I didn't want to get another yellow card for celebrating," said Frattesi, who came on 10 minutes before he scored.

The game wasn't won, though, until a penalty kick 10 minutes into added time from Verona striker Thomas Henry hit the post.

Then it was back to celebrating as Inter moved five points clear of Juventus, which visits last-placed Salernitana on Sunday.

Inter drew its previous match and was eliminated from the Italian Cup by Bologna in late December. This dramatic victory put Simone Inzaghi's team back on track for its title pursuit and the chance to stitch a second star onto its shirt to signify what would be a 20th Italian championship.

Juventus, with three stars and a record 36 Serie A titles, is the only club in Italy with more than one star.

"The tough games to win are the dirty ones — but they're also the ones that enable you to go all the way," Frattesi said.

The match started as expected, with Lautaro finishing off a swift vertical move.

Marcus Thuram used one touch with his back to the goal to leave the ball for Henrikh Mkhitaryan, who sent a diagonal pass toward Lautaro. The Argentina international, who missed two games with an injured left thigh, then controlled with his right foot and used the outside of the same foot to slot the ball in past Verona goalkeeper Lorenzo Montipò.

But Inter couldn't add to the advantage and Henry equalized seconds after coming on by using his knee to redirect in a cross in the 74th.

Inter forward Marko Arnautovic wasted more chances when he accidentally blocked a shot from going in and missed a header from point-blank range.

Frattesi finally restored Inter's lead when he tapped in a rebound after a volley from Alessandro Bastoni hit the crossbar.

But a foul from Matteo Darmian threatened to render Frattesi's celebration useless until Henry sent the ensuing penalty off the left post, with a follow-up header from Verona also missing the target.

Penalty Save

Fiorentina's pursuit of a Champions League spot took a hit with a 1-0 loss at Sassuolo, where Andrea Pinamonti put the hosts ahead early.

In the second half, Sassuolo goalkeeper Andrea Consigli saved a penalty kick from Giacomo Bonaventura.

The Viola remained in fourth place, one point ahead of Bologna, which was held to 1-1 by Genoa on Friday.

Also, Monza won at Frosinone 3-2 and moved up to 10th place; and Lecce and Cagliari drew 1-1.

Real, Atletico ease into Copa last 16

AP
Madrid, Jan. 7

Real Madrid easily handled fourth-division club Arandina 3-1 and moved into the round of 16 of the Copa del Rey on Saturday.

Joselu, Brahim Díaz and Rodrygo scored for the defending Copa champions, who also finally debuted young Turkey international Arda Güler after a series of injuries.

Also, Atletico Madrid defeated third-division club Lugo 3-1.

Real Madrid dominated, controlled possession, didn't allow Arandina to threaten much. It was given a late own-goal by Madrid defender Nacho Fernández.

Güler had some good scoring chances, including a free kick that struck the post in the first half. The 18-year-old midfielder arrived this season from Fenerbahce on a six-year contract. His debut was delayed by a knee injury in the offseason followed by a muscle problem.

Midfielder Eduardo Camavinga was back in the squad after injuring his knee while on international duty with France in November.

Depay leads Atletico

Memphis Depay scored twice in the second half as Atletico got past Lugo.

Ángel Correa also scored for Atletico, which was coming off a loss at Girona in La Liga. Atletico is 10 points off the lead at the league's halfway point.

Correa opened the scoring two minutes into the match, and Leandro Antonetti equalized for Lugo in the 39th.

Memphis, who hasn't often started this season, put Atletico ahead again in the 66th and added to the lead in the 74th.

Antoine Griezmann came into the match after halftime but failed to score, staying tied with Luis Aragonés as Atletico's all-time top scorer with 173.

Other first-division clubs to win during Epiphany, or Three Kings Day — one of the biggest holidays in Spain — included Getafe, Rayo Vallecano, Real Betis and Girona, the second-placed team in the league behind Madrid.

Girona beat Elche 2-0 and Getafe edged Espanyol 1-0, while Rayo Vallecano needed late goals in extra time to get past second-division club Huesca 2-0.

In a matchup between top-flight clubs, Alaves won against Real Betis 1-0 at home.

Barcelona takes on fourth-division club Barbastro on Sunday.

Madrid, Atletico, Barcelona and Osasuna are making their Copa debuts in this round, which is still played in single elimination games.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:56 am, Sunset at 5:25 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province, Gandaki Province and Karnali Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 17-19 Rain Probability: 0%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	15.7	2.9	0.0
Dipayal	23.6	2.8	0.0
Dhangadi	17.7	10.2	0.0
Birendranagar	22.0	5.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	19.5	11.6	0.0
Jumla	14.5	-5.4	0.0
Ghorahi	21.6	7.7	0.0
Pokhara	20.6	8.6	0.0
Bhairahawa	15.8	11.5	0.0
Simara	20.3	9.0	0.0
Kathmandu	17.8	4.2	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.6	7.2	0.0
Taplejung	16.5	5.2	0.0
Dhankuta	22.3	8.4	0.0
Biratnagar	23.2	10.5	0.0
Jomsom	10.1	-4.5	0.0*
Dharan	24.5	12.6	0.0*
Lumle	15.2	5.2	0.0*
Janakpur	23.0	14.4	0.0*
Jiri	15.2	-0.1	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 8, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.75	Rs. 133.35
Euro	1	Rs. 145.26	Rs. 145.91
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.83	Rs. 169.59
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 156.18	Rs. 156.88
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 89.13	Rs. 89.53
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.33	Rs. 99.78
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 99.84	Rs.100.29
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.18	Rs. 9.22
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.59	Rs. 18.67
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.40	Rs. 35.56
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.42	Rs. 36.59
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.83	Rs. 3.84
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.31
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.52	Rs. 28.65
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.09	Rs. 10.14
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.95	Rs. 13.01
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.48	Rs. 19.56
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.99	Rs. 17.07
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.71	Rs. 433.66
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.10	Rs. 353.69

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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